INDIANA JONES AND THE MOUNTAIN OF THE GODS

A Screenplay
Adapted from the novella

FADE IN:

EXT. BAY OF BISCAY - NIGHT

A full moon, too bright. Black water below. A few hundred feet above it, alone in the sky: a B-17 FLYING FORTRESS, one engine trailing smoke, droning north. Spray streaks the nose. The pilot is flying low on purpose, and everyone aboard is trying not to think about why.

SUPER: BAY OF BISCAY. SPRING, 1943.

INT. B-17 - WAIST - NIGHT

Cramped, rattling, freezing. Ammunition belts sag like bunting. The only light is a red bulb that makes everyone look like they're already in trouble.

SERGEANT PRIEST, thirties, Texan, works his gum like it owes him money. He is staring at the man across from him.

The man wears a fedora, pulled low, the brim bent by a decade of other people's bad ideas. A bruised leather jacket over a borrowed flight suit. A coiled bullwhip on his hip, which has become a topic of discussion aboard this aircraft.

INDIANA JONES, forty, eyes closed, does not look up.

PRIEST
Doc, it's twenty below. Why's the hat still on?

INDY
(eyes closed)
Because it's the only thing on this airplane I trust.

PRIEST
And the whip?

INDY
Don't.

PRIEST
Everybody's asking about the whip.

INDY
It's a long story.

PRIEST
We got eight hours.

INDY
It's a longer story.

Beside him sits WERNER LINDT, fifties, thin, ink on his thumbs, a soft felt hat he refuses to remove and a leather satchel clutched to his stomach like a sleeping child. He is peeling an orange. It is the only orange for a thousand miles, and he knows it.

LINDT
You will have some.

He splits it. Puts the larger half in Indy's hand.

INDY
I'm fine.

LINDT
It was not a question. In Berlin there are no oranges. My wife says it is an indulgence to eat what is not in season in one's own country.

INDY
Smart woman.

LINDT
She is in Hamburg. Or she is not.

He eats a segment with his eyes closed.

INDY
You'll be in London by breakfast. Kippers. Tea. A very small egg.

LINDT
I will be very happy with the egg.

Indy eats his half. It's very good.

The engines change pitch.

INT. B-17 - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

CAPTAIN DELGADO, thick, tidy, Tulsa, stares through the windscreen. One shape rides the moon off the starboard wing: a JUNKERS 88, heavy with cannon, keeping pace. It isn't attacking. It's pacing them.

DELGADO
(intercom)
Bandit, ten o'clock high. He's just sitting there. I don't like it. Gunners, light him up.

EXT. B-17 - TAIL - NIGHT

HOLLIS, twenty, a kid from Ohio, in the tail turret, opens up. Tracer fire tears across the dark and falls short of the Ju 88 by a mile.

INT. B-17 - WAIST - NIGHT

The whole airplane shudders with noise. Priest hammers at his gun. Indy is on his feet.

Something LANDS on the wing.

It isn't gunfire. A weight, settling where no weight should be. Indy feels it through the floor. He looks out the waist window.

A MAN is standing on the wing root.

Leather harness. Two steel canisters strapped to his back, trailing threads of fire. A few hundred feet over black water, two hundred miles an hour into the wind. Calm as a man on a train platform.

PRIEST
That can't be a man.

He keeps shooting anyway. His burst knocks the jumper off the wing. The man tumbles into the dark, canisters flaring, and hits the sea with a hiss.

INDY
(to himself)
OSS bulletin. Test field near Stargard. Manned rockets.

PRIEST
You read about these?

INDY
None of the bulletins said they climb bombers like a ladder.

The waist hatch BANGS. A second jumper drops through boots-first, pistol already out, canisters hissing on his back.

Indy's whip is in his hand before anyone sees him draw it. CRACK. It wraps the man's gun arm. The pistol fires into the ceiling. Indy yanks; the man pitches forward, and his hand slaps down against his own harness.

WHOOSH.

The canisters ignite inside the fuselage. The rocket man shoots the entire length of the airplane like a champagne cork, screaming, trailing fire, clips a hanging ammunition belt, and goes out the tail window in a spray of sparks.

Silence, except for the wind. Priest stares down the empty length of the plane.

PRIEST
Doc.

INDY
I know.

A THIRD jumper hits the tail with a CLANG. Hollis's guns stop.

HOLLIS (V.O.)
(muffled)
There's a guy on my turret! There's a guy on my turret!

PRIEST
Shoot him!

HOLLIS (V.O.)
He's standing on my GUN!

Indy is already running for the radio room.

INT. B-17 - RADIO ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Lindt, the color of an eggshell, pressed against the bulkhead, satchel locked to his chest.

INDY
Stay down.

Lindt says something in German that doesn't need translating.

The tail window EXPLODES inward. A FOURTH jumper swings through on a line, rifle shouldered. There is no time. One shot, flat and small in all that noise.

Lindt slides down the bulkhead. A dark hole in his chest nobody saw happen.

The jumper tears the satchel off Lindt's shoulder. Indy hits him at a dead run. They crash through the radio table. The man breaks free, backs onto the sill, and slaps his harness.

WHOOSH. He goes out the window like a cork, satchel strap in his fist.

Indy's whip is already in the air. It catches the strap. The line goes taut and Indy leaves his feet, skates across the floor, fetches up against the window frame with his boots braced on the sill. Half a second to decide.

He takes it.

EXT. B-17 - TAIL - NIGHT

Indy slams belly-down onto the horizontal stabilizer, one hand clawing at frozen metal, the whip handle in the other. The slipstream tears the fedora off his head and pins it against the tail fin, where it flaps like a trapped bird.

Twenty feet away the rocket man hangs on twin flames, towing the satchel on its strap and Indy on the whip. Beyond him, the Ju 88 holds station, patient as a hearse.

A tug-of-war at two hundred miles an hour. Indy digs his boots into a seam in the aluminum. The strap sings. The satchel strains toward the Ju 88.

INDY
Come on, come on, come on—

The strap TEARS.

The satchel streaks away into the dark. The rocket man catches the Ju 88's wing and is hauled in like a fish. Indy is left holding the whip, and at the end of it a ragged triangle of leather torn from the satchel's flap.

In the Ju 88's glass nose an OFFICER in a pale flying coat lifts two fingers to the peak of his cap. Polite. Almost friendly.

The Ju 88 banks away. The dark swallows it.

Indy flicks the whip free of the leather. The lash snaps back, curls over the fin and plucks the fedora off it like a carny at a county fair. It drops into his hand.

He looks at it. Looks around for a witness. There is no one but the sea.

INDY
Nobody saw that.

He jams the hat on and starts crawling forward.

INT. B-17 - RADIO ROOM - NIGHT

Indy drops through the broken window, breathing hard, hat on crooked.

Lindt lies against the bulkhead. His half of the orange is on the floor beside him, one segment gone.

Indy kneels. Closes the man's eyes. Takes off his own hat for exactly one second. Puts it back on.

INSERT - THE LEATHER FLAP

Stitched inside it: a folded sheet. On one side, typed orders under an eagle and an oak-leaf wreath. On the other, a pencil sketch in Lindt's own hand: a valley ringed with peaks, a tiny X. In the margin of the orders, in a different hand, one word, underlined twice:

Shambhala.

DELGADO (V.O.)
(intercom, thin)
Who's alive back there?

INDY
(into the mic)
Not enough of us. Lindt's gone.

DELGADO (V.O.)
Hollis says he'd like it on the record he flare-gunned a man off his turret. And that Ju 88's gone home. Four men dropped on my airplane, Doctor, and the other fellow just left. Whatever they came for, what did they get?

INDY
Half.

He looks at the page. Then at the orange.

SMASH CUT TO BLACK.

Silence. Then one low, brassy chord. White letters, like a stone coming out of the dark:

INDIANA JONES AND THE MOUNTAIN OF THE GODS

Over black, the sound of a steam press. HISS. THUMP.

INT. MAJOR SHAW'S OFFICE - LONDON - MORNING

Two rooms above a tailor's shop on Grosvenor Street. The blackout curtains are torn, so pale light falls across the desk in strips. The half-sheet lies flat under paperweights: a brass owl, a chipped inkwell, a stapler. The paper keeps trying to curl.

Downstairs, the tailor's presser. HISS. THUMP. Every thump walks the brass owl a quarter inch toward the edge of the desk.

MAJOR WALTER SHAW, fifties, gray with exhaustion, polishes his glasses on a handkerchief. Indy stands at the window, unshaven, still in the flight suit, hat back on, whip coiled at his hip like it never left.

SHAW
Lindt's dead. You've brought me half a sheet of paper.

INDY
Four men came out of the dark on rocket harnesses to get his bag. I got you what they missed.

SHAW
Somebody wanted what he carried.

He turns the page so Indy can read it. The eagle. The oak-leaf wreath.

INDY
The Ahnenerbe.

SHAW
The SS research outfit that does most of its studying with calipers, pointed at the skulls of the living. This is an operational order. Fuel, pack animals, cold-weather gear rated for altitude. Project shelved in thirty-nine, revived last autumn. A valley in Tibet, Jones. Three hundred miles from a railhead. Signed by an Obersturmbannführer Erich Kessler, doctor of anthropology.

INDY
What's in the valley?

SHAW
The order says "the find." Twice. In quotation marks both times.

Indy turns the page toward the light. The margin. That one word, underlined twice.

INDY
Shambhala.

SHAW
Bless you.

INDY
A professor in Vienna told me about it once. I didn't like him. A lost homeland nobody can find on a map.

SHAW
And?

INDY
They believe it. That's worse than if they didn't.

THUMP. The owl reaches the edge. Without looking, Indy's whip hand flicks; the lash snaps out, catches the owl mid-fall, and deposits it back on the desk. Shaw doesn't look up. He hasn't noticed since 1941.

SHAW
There's an American mission going to Lhasa this spring. Real, above-board. Two men with the President's letters and gifts for the boy on the throne. Nobody blinks at a third American joining as academic adviser. You'd fit the part without acting.

INDY
And once I'm there?

SHAW
You find out what the Ahnenerbe thinks it lost. And you make sure, by whatever means necessary, that it stays lost.

He pushes a folder across. A passport with Indy's face. A letter from the State Department. A second letter on the stationery of a college in Connecticut.

SHAW (CONT'D)
Marshall's dean has agreed to call it a sabbatical. He asked if you'd be back for spring term. I said I couldn't speak to that.

INDY
What did he say?

SHAW
That the Egyptology section is a shambles and your lecture hall smells of gas. I took it to mean he likes you.

INDY
He doesn't. He wants me to stop turning in grades late.

SHAW
Then the cover is perfect.

INDY
Why me?

SHAW
Donovan signed off personally. Asked for you by name. Said something about a mask in Mexico and a notebook in Havana, and a habit of getting things back from men who shouldn't have them.

INDY
When do I leave?

SHAW
You already have.

THUMP. The owl goes off the desk again. This time Indy lets it. It drops through a rotten floorboard. From the tailor's shop below: a short, outraged cry.

SHAW (CONT'D)
Leave it.

SMASH CUT TO:

INSERT - A MAP OF THE WORLD

A red line crawls across it to the beat of brisk, climbing engines. LONDON. GIBRALTAR. CAIRO. KARACHI. CALCUTTA. At each stop a rubber stamp comes down on a ticket in the corner of frame, and a hat brim sinks a little lower. The line reaches the top of India and keeps climbing, into the blank white place where the map gives up.

EXT. THE HIMALAYA - DAY

Snow-capped peaks rise through broken cloud like teeth through gum. We are close. Too close.

SUPER: THE HUMP. INDIA-TIBET FRONTIER.

INT. C-47 - COCKPIT - DAY

Indy in the jump seat, a down jacket that smells of someone else's tobacco, the fedora held in both hands on his knee. The CO-PILOT makes small, urgent corrections.

CO-PILOT
Lost eleven planes off this route last month. Weather, mostly. Sometimes the Japanese. Mostly weather.

INDY
Comforting.

CO-PILOT
I didn't say it to comfort you.

A wall of granite fills the windscreen. The pilot hauls the yoke. The plane claws up and over the ridge with fifty feet to spare.

Indy puts his hat back on, very slowly.

EXT. NATU LA - ROPE BRIDGE - DAY

A cane-and-rope span over a gorge, swaying in the wind, planks missing like bad teeth. Two hundred feet of nothing below it, and a white river at the bottom having a better time than anyone up here.

On the far side, a pack train of porters. Two PILGRIMS in rough robes sit by the anchor post, spinning prayer wheels, patient as stones.

Indy, sunburned, hollow-eyed, leads a gray gelding MULE. One white ear. Strong opinions about bridges.

The mule stops dead at the edge. Looks at the drop. Refuses.

DAWA, fifteen, a Lepcha muleteer, calls out something to the porters across the gap. They howl with laughter.

INDY
What did he say?

DAWA
He says the mule has more sense than the American.

Indy hands him the rope. Steps onto the bridge. The cane creaks like a ship's timber.

Halfway across he notices three things. The porters have gone quiet. The pilgrims have stopped spinning their wheels. And under the hem of one robe, a boot. Polished. Nobody in the Himalaya polishes his boots.

INDY
(pleasantly)
Hello.

Both pilgrims stand. Two long knives come out of the robes. They go to work on the anchor ropes.

The left cable PARTS. The bridge lurches sideways. Planks slide out from under Indy's boots. He doesn't drop flat. He RUNS, uphill along a sagging bridge, straight at them.

The first pilgrim pulls a pistol from his sash. Indy is twenty feet away and closing. CRACK. The whip takes the pistol out of the man's hand and sends it spinning into the gorge. The man stares at his empty fingers.

PILGRIM
(in German, to himself)
Verdammt.

The second pilgrim hacks the last cable.

The bridge drops out from under Indy like a trapdoor. He leaps. The whip lashes around the anchor post; Indy swings out over the gorge, slams into the cliff face below the lip, and hangs there, one-handed, as the whole bridge falls away behind him. Planks tumble for a very long time.

Across the gap, on the near side, Dawa watches with his mouth open. The mule does not. The mule has seen this coming.

Indy looks up. Two pilgrims look down.

INDY
Boys.

A knife comes down. Indy catches the wrist and for one ugly moment the whole world is a man's teeth and a drop. He kicks the man's ankle out. The first pilgrim goes over the edge with a rope still tangled around his boot, hauled down by the tail of the fallen bridge.

The second brings up his knife. Indy's boot meets the middle of his robe. The man staggers back onto the lip of the cliff. The whip finds his ankle. A tug.

He's gone. The gorge doesn't even echo.

Indy hauls himself over the edge and lies on his back with his hat over his face. The porters stare at him from behind a boulder. Nobody says anything.

Twenty minutes later. Half a mile upstream, where the gorge opens out and the river spreads thin over flat stones, Dawa leads the mule across a ford. The mule walks through the water with its eyes open, unhurried.

INDY
(from under the hat)
There's a ford.

DAWA
There is always a ford.

INDY
Why didn't anyone mention it?

DAWA
The mule did.

The mule arrives. Shakes itself like a dog, soaking Indy.

DAWA (CONT'D)
I did say. The mule has more sense.

EXT. GANGTOK BAZAAR - DAY

A crowded market, prayer flags overhead. A tailor with a cast in one eye measures Indy twice. A cobbler resoles his boots in yak hide. A woman at a stall presses a twist of dried cheese into his hand and mimes: suck it, don't chew it.

Indy pockets it, bewildered.

At a trinket stall, a MERCHANT lifts a shriveled brown thing on a stand with great ceremony.

MERCHANT
Yeti scalp, sahib. Very old.

INDY
That's a goat.

MERCHANT
Sahib is collector?

INDY
Sahib is expert.

He sets the "scalp" down. Behind him, half hidden by a stack of prayer wheels, a figure in a fur-lined cap, copper hair tucked beneath it, watches. A camera strap. A glint of glass.

The figure ducks out of sight as Indy turns. Prayer wheels spin. Nothing there.

EXT. THE RESIDENCY LAWN - GANGTOK - DAY

A lawn at the edge of the world. A thousand feet of air beyond it.

GERALD WHITCOMBE, His Majesty's Political Officer for Sikkim, narrow, sunburned, in shirtsleeves, tees up a golf ball.

WHITCOMBE
Only course in Sikkim. Par three. A thousand feet of air, and the hazard is a river.

He swings. The ball sails out over the gorge and is gone.

WHITCOMBE (CONT'D)
Shaw's cable said you'd come through eventually. He didn't say on foot.

INDY
I had help. Two pilgrims with very good boots tried to push me off a mountain.

Whitcombe's second swing goes into a hedge.

WHITCOMBE
Germans?

INDY
Dead ones, now.

WHITCOMBE
Ah. Then they have people this side of the border, which is more than I was told.

He presses a club into Indy's hands like a man recruiting.

WHITCOMBE (CONT'D)
Here's what we know, and I'd rather not say how.

INDY
Wireless intercept.

WHITCOMBE
Which is why London can't simply protest to Lhasa. The moment the Kashag asks how we know, we've told Berlin which of its codes we read. Hence a professor instead of a démarche.

Indy swings. The ball veers off at an angle that suggests it has somewhere to be.

WHITCOMBE (CONT'D)
A German party crossed in last autumn, calling itself a trade delegation, which fooled nobody, since trade delegations don't carry theodolites and crates stenciled with a Reich eagle. They're in a valley three days east of Lhasa. The Tibetans call it Shomo. The quiet place. Run by Obersturmbannführer Erich Kessler, who was in that same valley in thirty-nine and has apparently spent four years wanting to go back.

INDY
The page had a word in the margin. Shambhala.

Whitcombe lowers the club. His face goes still.

WHITCOMBE
That word gets men killed up here, Dr. Jones. And not always by other men.

He retrieves his bag, which means the round is over.

WHITCOMBE (CONT'D)
What I can tell you is what we've seen. Caravans going in, heavier each time. Crates two porters can't lift. And six weeks ago a Tibetan trader who runs that route came through Gangtok white as a sheet. Wouldn't say why. Hasn't been back.

INDY
I need a guide.

WHITCOMBE
There's a trading post three days east called Rateng. Ask for Tsering Wangmo. She runs pack trains for the wool traders and knows every goat track to the Chinese border. Her brother went in with the Germans in thirty-nine as a guide and didn't come out.

He hands Indy a sealed envelope.

WHITCOMBE (CONT'D)
A letter of introduction. It will do you no good whatever. She regards the Political Officer as a sort of weather.

INDY
Then why give it to me?

WHITCOMBE
So that if you don't come back, someone can say whom to ask.

He tees up the last ball.

WHITCOMBE (CONT'D)
(rather gently, to the valley)
Fore.

He hits it into the clouds.

EXT. THE OLD MAN PASS - A LEDGE ABOVE A RIVER - DAY

Dawn. Mist in the gorges. The road out of Gangtok toward Rateng climbs into thinner air.

A ledge two mules wide, cut into a mountainside that goes up on the left until it stops being rock and becomes weather, and drops on the right to a river like a dropped thread.

Indy rides the gray gelding. Dawa leads, with two porters and a short train of pack animals behind.

DAWA
Two men behind us. Since Gangtok.

He doesn't turn his head.

DAWA (CONT'D)
Their ponies are good. Their coats are good. Their boots are very good.

Indy has been watching those boots for a day and a half. Nobody in the Himalaya polishes his boots.

Half a mile back, two RIDERS in sheepskin coats keep pace with the patience of men who've been told to wait for a better place.

The road gives them one.

Ahead, the shelf narrows to a church pew and crosses a scar of old rockfall. Above it, wedged in the cliff like a bad tooth, hangs a boulder the size of a bullock cart, knotted with prayer flags.

DAWA (CONT'D)
That is the Old Man. Every spring the mountain tries to take him. Every spring the lamas climb up and tie a new flag. He has not fallen in ninety years.

INDY
Does he know that?

DAWA
He is a rock.

BEHIND THEM, a pistol CRACKS.

The bullet hits the cliff a yard ahead of the gelding's nose. Dawa hits the dirt. The porters drop their loads and sprint for the bend. And the gelding, who has stopped exactly once for a reason in two hundred miles, stops again, all four feet planted.

Indy rolls off on the cliff side and puts the mule between himself and the road.

INDY
Good mule.

The mule does not care. It is eight hundred pounds of firm opinion. For the first time since the cane bridge, Indy is grateful for it.

Under the gelding's belly: two riders, forty yards off, coming at a walk like men with all the time in the world.

Indy has six rounds and a revolver that throws left. He looks at the riders. At the narrow place on the shelf. At the Old Man.

INDY (CONT'D)
Tell me when the first pony is under the flags.

DAWA
(lifting his face from the dirt)
You want to shoot the mountain.

INDY
I want to ask it a favor.

He fires. A prayer flag tears off the line. He fires again, chipping the Old Man above a dark seam where meltwater has been working at the stone for a hundred years.

Nothing happens.

The lead rider LAUGHS, one short bark, and comes on.

DAWA
Perhaps he does not like you.

INDY
Tell me when.

DAWA
Now.

Indy puts the third round into the seam. The fourth.

A long groan, like a ship settling.

The Old Man LEANS, politely, as if asked to move down a pew. Then the whole hillside goes.

A slab the size of a house front pours across the shelf with a roar like a freight yard. Pony, Mauser, man: gone in a wall of brown dust. Indy drags Dawa flat under the cliff as a rock the size of a bread oven goes over their heads, close enough to part his hair, and out into nothing.

The dust thins. Forty yards of shelf are gone. In their place lies raw rubble, and across it, knee-deep, holding his rifle over his head like a man fording a river, comes the SECOND RIDER.

No pony. No cap. Not a word. He picks his way from stone to stone with terrible manners.

Indy fires once. The dust has done something to his aim. The man swings the rifle down, fires from the hip, and shoots the heel off Indy's boot.

INDY (CONT'D)
Rope! The lead rope. Give me the end!

He knots it round the gelding's pack frame. The gelding does not twitch.

INDY (CONT'D)
Stay behind the mule.

DAWA
Behind the mule?

INDY
Everyone should.

He walks out toward the rider with both hands wide and empty, like a man about to surrender.

Behind him, Dawa, who has been tying things to mules since he was six, flicks a loop of rope along the ground.

The rider takes one more step to be sure. His boot goes into the loop.

The other end is tied to the one object in the Himalaya that will not move.

The rider goes down on his face, rifle skating away. Indy is on him before he stops bouncing.

It's not a clean fight. The rubble slides under them like a conveyor belt. The man is lean, fast, trained by someone good. Twice Indy finds a knife where he didn't expect one. But the loop holds, and the mountain is still moving, and the last foot of shelf, which has been holding on out of habit, quits.

They go over together.

Indy's hand finds a root. His other hand finds the man's wrist.

For a second he has him. The rider hangs above a thousand feet of river and looks up at Indy with perfect calm. Indy understands that he has already decided what kind of prisoner he will be.

INDY (CONT'D)
Don't.

The man opens his hand.

Indy watches him fall until the spray swallows him.

Quiet. The porters creep back round the bend, not meeting anyone's eye. The gelding steps calmly forward onto the new rubble and begins to crop a tuft of grass growing out of the wreckage, as if the whole affair had been somebody else's idea.

Indy hauls himself up. Looks at his missing boot heel. At the mule.

INDY (CONT'D)
You could have helped.

The mule chews.

EXT. RATENG - TRADING POST - DAY

Less a town than an idea of one. Stone houses with barley drying on the roofs. A monastery painted the color of old blood. A market square where yak-hair tents trade in salt, wool and rumor in roughly equal measure.

Indy limps through it, one boot heel missing, asking for a name. Three traders give him three directions: the universal response of people who've decided a stranger's business isn't theirs to speed along.

A fourth, an OLD TRADER missing most of his teeth, looks at Indy's boots. At his hands.

OLD TRADER
You're not here for wool.

INDY
No.

OLD TRADER
Then you're here about the valley.

He spits, with ceremony, onto the frozen ground.

OLD TRADER (CONT'D)
Her tent is at the east edge, past the prayer wheels. One thing. She does not like to be thanked. If you thank her, she will charge you. I thanked her once, for mending a harness. Two rupees. I have not thanked anyone since.

INDY
Understood.

EXT. TSERING'S TENT - RATENG - CONTINUOUS

Black yak-hair stretched over lashed poles. Beside it, a small cairn of the kind built for the dead when there is no body to bury.

TSERING WANGMO, early thirties, a head shorter than Indy and has not noticed, crouches at a cookfire resetting a packsaddle buckle with hands that have done it ten thousand times. She looks up with the flat appraisal of a woman who decided before he opened his mouth that whatever he wants is going to cost her.

TSERING
You're the American. The trader with no teeth sent a boy ahead.

INDY
News travels fast.

TSERING
News is the only thing that does. You want to go into Shomo.

INDY
I need a guide.

TSERING
I know a great many countries. I don't go into that one.

She goes back to the saddle. The conversation is over. Except she hasn't told him to leave.

INDY
The Germans there now are the ones who went in four years ago. I was told your brother guided that expedition.

Her hands stop.

INDY (CONT'D)
I was told he didn't come back.

TSERING
You were told a great deal for a man who's been in Rateng half an hour.

She stands.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Why do you want into that valley? The truth. Not the version you'd give a magistrate.

INDY
A month ago four of their men attacked my plane using rocket harnesses strapped to their backs. To get at a defector. The defector's papers say they're going back to Shomo to finish something they started in thirty-nine. I don't know what. I know my government is scared enough of the answer to fly me around half the world.

TSERING
That is honest. It is not why you came to my tent instead of someone else's.

INDY
I was told you hate that valley as much as I'm going to.

Something crosses her face. Quick, controlled. A wound that scarred over wrong and still pulls when the weather changes.

TSERING
Hold this.

That is as close to an invitation as he's going to get.

"This" is a BLACK MARE's cracked left hind hoof. Tsering bends the leg up and puts the whole thing in Indy's hands. The mare leans her full weight on him to see what will happen. Tsering takes a rasp from her belt and goes to work.

She passes him a bowl of salted, buttered tea without apology. He drinks it one-handed with a horse leaning on him, because refusing would cost more than the taste.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Do you pray?

INDY
Not often.

TSERING
Do you believe in what the Germans are looking for?

INDY
I believe in what people will do for it. I watched a man cross a desert on his knees for a piece of wood. It was only wood. I never told him.

The rasp stops. The mare shifts another hundred pounds onto him.

TSERING
That is a bad answer. It is the answer of a man who has been disappointed.

She says it without unkindness, the way she might say a horse favors the near side.

TSERING (CONT'D)
I would rather you believed in something. A man who believes in nothing runs the wrong way when the shooting starts.

INDY
I believe in my notebook.

TSERING
Then keep it dry.

She refills the bowl. The mare shifts. The new tea goes down Indy's leg.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Like that.

Beside the tent, a big YAK-CROSS has been eating Indy's fedora since he sat down. It has reached the crown. Indy notices at the word "calipers."

TSERING (CONT'D)
Don't pull. She will swallow it out of spite.

He lets go. The hat goes in by inches. Neither of them mentions it again.

Tsering drives a nail into the mare's new shoe at the end of each sentence, so her brother's whole life arrives in short hard strokes.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Norbu. The best high-altitude man in three valleys. Better than our father, who taught him. The Germans hired him in thirty-eight for more money than our family had seen in a decade. At first he wrote proud letters about the young scientist in charge. A serious one, who measured people's heads with brass calipers.

Nail.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Then he stopped writing about the measuring. He wrote about a place high in Shomo that the herders wouldn't graze near for double the fees.

Nail.

TSERING (CONT'D)
The official story is that he died of altitude sickness on the descent, four days before the expedition left. My brother had walked those heights since he was twelve. He did not die of altitude sickness. In four years nobody in that expedition has explained it to me. I have asked in more than one language.

The fire pops.

INDY
And now the same man is going back.

TSERING
With more crates and more men and more rocket harnesses than the first time. And an American who says his own government is afraid of the answer has walked into my tent and drunk my tea.

She looks at him. Nothing soft in it. But nothing closed either, which is as far open as Tsering's face goes.

TSERING (CONT'D)
I will take you to Shomo, Dr. Jones. Not for your government. Not for mine. I am going to stand in that valley and learn what my brother saw that was worth killing him to keep quiet.

She drives the last nail and sets the hoof down. The mare, released, immediately stands on Indy's foot.

INDY
Agreed.

TSERING
I haven't finished. The whole truth, every time. Whatever you learn about my brother, you tell me. Even the parts you think will spare me. I have had four years of people deciding what I could bear to hear. I am finished with that kind of kindness.

INDY
Agreed.

And he means it more the second time. He made that exact promise once on a different dock to a different woman, and very nearly didn't keep it.

TSERING
Forty rupees a day. The feed for the animals is yours.

Indy counts what's left of Shaw's money.

INDY
I have thirty-eight.

TSERING
Then we go for one day less than planned.

INDY
That isn't how it works.

TSERING
It is how it works in my tent. By the second day you will owe me more than you have. A man pays better when he is in debt.

INDY
Is that a general principle?

TSERING
It is arithmetic.

She drops his pack on a scale made of two baskets and a pole and begins unloading it onto a carpet. The sulfa powder she approves. The salt tablets she sniffs and puts aside. A Sanskrit grammar she holds up between two fingers like a dead mouse.

TSERING (CONT'D)
It weighs one kilo. At fifteen thousand feet one kilo is two.

INDY
If I find anything written down there, I'll need it.

TSERING
If you find anything written down there, you will need to be alive.

She opens it to the middle, tears out forty pages, hands them over folded.

TSERING (CONT'D)
These. The rest stays. I will keep it for you.

INDY
That's not how you treat a book.

TSERING
It is how I treat a mule. I do not carry what it does not need.

She lifts the bullwhip out of the pack by its handle and lets it uncoil down her arm like something that might still be alive.

TSERING (CONT'D)
And this.

INDY
That stays.

TSERING
It is a rope that holds nothing.

INDY
It holds more than you'd think.

She considers him. Flicks her wrist at a tent peg six feet away. The lash takes the peg out of the ground and lays it in her open palm. She looks at it, unimpressed, and hands the whip back.

TSERING (CONT'D)
It is a rope with opinions. Keep it. It weighs less than your book.

She counts his socks next, laying them in a row like dead fish. Frowns.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Three.

INDY
I had four.

TSERING
Then someone is walking behind you wearing one.

She says it without looking up, as a remark about mule feed, and goes on unloading. Indy, tired and cold, takes it for a joke.

On the far side of the market, among the tents, a camera lens catches the sun for half a second. Then it's gone.

Tsering walks him behind the tent to the pack animals tied in a line. The black mare, whose hoof he now knows personally, is vain. The big yak-cross is lazy. The little GRAY MULE at the end will carry anything and bite anyone who stands behind it.

TSERING (CONT'D)
This one is yours.

INDY
The biting one.

TSERING
The honest one.

She holds the lamp to his boots. The yak-hide soles from Gangtok are already splitting. She goes into the tent and comes back with a pair of felt-lined boots that belonged to someone larger than her brother and smaller than Indy.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Try.

They're a size too small. He says they fit.

TSERING (CONT'D)
You are lying. Good. It means you will complain less.

INDY
What do I owe you?

TSERING
Nothing. They were not mine to sell.

She doesn't say whose they were, and Indy has the sense not to ask. He walks back toward the fire in boots that pinch, past a cairn he decides not to look at.

TSERING (CONT'D)
We leave at first light. Four days to the valley floor. Get what sleep you can, American. It will be the last easy sleep either of us has for some time.

EXT. HIGH PASS - DAY

Sixteen thousand feet. Wind like paper tearing. A pack train of nine animals crawls up a ridge in single file.

Indy, ghost-white, stops every few hundred yards, hands on his knees. Every time he does, Tsering stops too, three paces ahead, and waits with her back to him.

At the top stands a cairn the height of a man, hung with white prayer flags. She walks around it once, clockwise, touching a stone. Indy, who has been to enough ruins to know when not to joke, waits.

TSERING
You are slow.

INDY
I'm aware.

TSERING
Eat.

She hands him a pouch of tsampa and shows him how to knead it with tea into a gray lump. He eats. It tastes like toasted flour and sits like a stone.

TSERING (CONT'D)
My brother ate this every morning for twenty years. He said it was the only food that never disappointed him.

It's the first time she's mentioned Norbu unasked. Indy chews and says nothing. She seems to find that acceptable.

TSERING (CONT'D)
The Germans will not walk this pass. There is a road on the other side, and Germans like roads. Four days. Not five. If you faint, I leave you at the next cairn.

INDY
That's the most comforting thing anyone's said to me this month.

TSERING
I was not trying to comfort you.

She starts down.

EXT. THE SNOWFIELD - DAY

Below the pass the trail drops onto a snowfield the size of a parade ground. Indy's boots crunch. Under each step the snow answers with a hollow, drumlike note, as though the mountain has been built with a room in it.

Tsering stops the train with one raised hand and tilts her head, like a woman listening to a stranger in the next room.

TSERING
One at a time. Quietly. If anything speaks, it will not be to you.

INDY
The snow?

TSERING
Everything.

They're a hundred and fifty yards across when the sky begins to HUM.

A low three-note chord, coming up from the north. Indy feels it in his teeth. Over the ridge, low enough that he can see the corrugations on its skin, comes a JUNKERS 52, painted the dull gray of old pewter, droning toward the valley with something heavy in its belly.

TSERING (CONT'D)
(very quietly)
The iron bird. It comes every ten days. Dr. Jones. Do you hear the snow?

He does. It sounds like a crowd drawing breath.

A single flat CRACK, like a rifle shot in a cathedral. A bright line shoots across the slope a hundred yards above them, thin as a pencil mark.

For one full second an acre of snow sits there, thinking about it.

Then it sighs, and begins to slide.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Cut the rope!

Her knife is out. The lead line parts.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Across! Not down, across!

She slaps the nearest mule on the rump. Nine animals who have been told all their lives not to bolt discover they've been given permission. They scatter along the slope in a spray of bells, and the slope comes after them with a sound like a train going into a tunnel.

Indy runs. The snow comes up to his knees like wet cement. The roar is behind him. Beside him.

A hand closes on his collar and hauls him onto something hard and curved that smells powerfully of yak: a bowed, heavy PACKSADDLE of lashed wood and hide, shaped, if you're generous and in a hurry, like a tin tray.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Sit.

INDY
On what?

TSERING
On that.

She drops onto it behind him, arms locked round his waist, boots braced.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Lean when I lean. Do not fight it.

INDY
How do I steer?

TSERING
You do not steer.

INDY
What do I do?

TSERING
You pray.

INDY
To what?

TSERING
Whatever you like. The mountain is not particular.

The avalanche reaches them. The world goes white and fast.

EXT. THE AVALANCHE - CONTINUOUS

It isn't a fall. It's a ride.

The saddle skates out onto the crest of the slide with the whole slope roaring underneath. Tsering leans left; Indy leans left. A BOULDER the size of a car comes out of the white dead ahead.

TSERING
Right!

She says it in exactly the tone she uses for pack lists. They round the boulder so close he feels the cold come off the rock.

INDY
You said I don't steer!

TSERING
You do not! That was leaning!

INDY
What's the difference?

TSERING
Steering is what you were doing before I told you not to!

The slope ends in a lip of black rock with nothing beyond it but air.

INDY
Tsering—

TSERING
Now!

She throws her weight forward. The saddle kicks off the lip like a ski jump.

They sail out over a hundred feet of empty space in a spray of snow and splintered wood, and for one long moment Indiana Jones hangs over the Himalaya on a yak's packsaddle with an extremely calm Tibetan woman and thinks, with perfect clarity, that nobody at Marshall College is ever going to believe a word of this.

They land in the soft wreck of the runout, bounce twice, and come to rest in a drift. Silence so thick it rings. The saddle is in a dozen pieces.

TSERING (CONT'D)
(from somewhere under his left arm)
Count.

INDY
Count what?

TSERING
Your fingers.

INDY
Ten.

TSERING
Then you may count the mules.

EXT. GRAVEL BAR BELOW THE SLOPE - LATER

The mules stand a quarter mile down, shaking snow off their coats in disgust. Tsering counts twice. Her shoulders come down an inch.

The honest gray stands apart on a boulder, looking back up the mountain with the smug expression of an animal proved right about everything.

High above, the Junkers drones on over the ridge, wingtips glinting, its crew admiring the scenery.

INDY
They didn't even know we were there. I think that's worse.

TSERING
It is how the mountain is, too.

She shakes snow from her hair.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Nothing in these valleys has ever set out to kill anyone. It is only ever in the way.

INDY
Then I'll make a point of staying out of its way.

TSERING
No. You will not.

She goes to count the mules again.

EXT. THE BOUNDARY STONES - DAY

A shelf of black rock below the last pass, where the trail runs between two rows of standing slabs, each the height of a man, leaning like old teeth. Lichen has eaten their faces. No cairn. No prayer flags. Even the mules slow down.

Tsering stops the train. She does not step between the stones. She walks around them.

INDY
Problem?

TSERING
Herders go around. Always. Nobody remembers why. That is how you know it is old.

Indy has already stepped between them. Of course he has. He crouches at the nearest slab and wipes the lichen away with his sleeve.

Carvings. A line of tall figures, long in the arm, hands raised, palms out. Under them, a row of strokes cut in groups of five: four short, one long across. Row under row, going back until the stone gives out.

INDY (CONT'D)
Pre-Buddhist. Bön, maybe older. Nobody carved a prayer flag on this. No gods. No lamas. Just people, standing there with their hands open.

TSERING
A warning.

INDY
Everybody says warning. Look at the hands. A warning holds up one palm. This is both. It isn't stop. It's we're here.

He traces the line of strokes.

INDY (CONT'D)
A border marker. Somebody saying, this is where we live, and we'd like you to knock. But why count a border?

TSERING
To know when someone crosses.

Neither of them says anything for a while. The wind moves through the gap between the slabs and makes a sound very close to a word.

Indy takes a page from the forty she left him, lays it across the carving, and rubs it with the flat of his pencil until the figures come up white out of the gray. He folds it into his jacket. Then he stands, looks at the stones, looks at the woman who walked around them with a thousand years of herders in her feet, and steps out of the row the long way, around the last slab.

TSERING (CONT'D)
You walked through.

INDY
I'm walking out.

TSERING
That is not how it works.

INDY
Is that a general principle?

TSERING
It is manners.

EXT. RIDGE ABOVE SHOMO - DAY

The valley opens below them: gray, treeless, immense. At its far end a column of woodsmoke rises thin and steady into air too cold to hold it.

Indy has gone pale and slow. Altitude has been quietly eating his thinking for days. Tsering sits him on a rock and looks him over like a woman choosing a horse.

TSERING
What is your mother's name?

INDY
Why?

TSERING
Answer.

INDY
Eleanor.

It arrives half a second late, like a stranger stepping off the wrong train.

TSERING
How many mules do I have?

INDY
Eleven. Twelve, with mine.

TSERING
Nine. Two stayed at the last pass. You watched me tie them.

She waits.

TSERING (CONT'D)
That is the mountain, not your mind. Count again, and count what is there.

He counts. Nine, standing in a line on the shale, one of them biting. It takes most of a minute.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Good. Most men count what they expect.

Behind the camp, at the valley's far end, a peak stands apart from the others. A white tooth with its head in cloud. The ground rises toward it in a long clean ramp, as if the whole valley were built to approach it.

INDY
What's that one called?

TSERING
Lhari. The mountain of the gods. Every ridge in Tibet is called that by somebody.

She doesn't look at it.

TSERING (CONT'D)
The herders here do not say it aloud. It is not a name. It is an address.

She pulls him down behind a shoulder of granite.

TSERING (CONT'D)
We watch today. If we go down now with no plan beyond wanting to see, we end up where my brother ended up.

They lie on their stomachs. Field glasses go back and forth.

Below: six large tents. A generator shed with a stovepipe. A mule line. Twenty-two men, a corporal who patrols whistling the same eight bars, and three civilians in good coats who never carry rifles and never stay outdoors more than a few minutes.

INDY
Scientists.

TSERING
They walk like men who have been told they will not need to be here long.

And roped off by itself, with fence posts and wire: a second enclosure that holds nothing Indy can see moving.

INDY
That fence wasn't in Lindt's drawings. A survey camp doesn't fence off empty ground unless there's something in it they don't want getting out.

At noon, the WIND STOPS.

Not a lull. It ceases, all at once. The silence is so total Indy hears the blood in his ears. Down in the camp, the German flags go limp.

TSERING
(murmuring)
The herders say the wind stops here every noon for as long as it takes to say one prayer. They say the mountain is listening. Do not speak until it passes.

Ninety seconds. A mule shifts. A man coughs half a mile away. A tin cup is set down on a table.

Then the wind comes back with a long dry rush, and the valley goes back to being merely a place where men work.

EXT. RIDGE ABOVE SHOMO - DUSK

A bell rings. The whole camp goes to dinner at once. Only two GUARDS stay out, standing by the pen. One takes off his gloves to light a cigarette, puts them back on, and never once looks at the fence behind him.

It is the first thing all day that frightens Indy.

INDY
A man doesn't turn his back on a lion cage for no reason. He does it when he's been told the lion is asleep.

He sketches the camp by pencil stub. Tsering takes the notebook, looks at it for ten seconds, and turns it upside down.

TSERING
You have the shed too close to the pen. The wind comes from the shed to the fence. They put it there so the smell goes the other way.

INDY
What smell?

TSERING
There is an animal in a hole. It does not use a latrine.

She jabs the page.

TSERING (CONT'D)
And the mules are not in a corral. They are on a rope. You can tell because the rope sags when they lean.

INDY
I couldn't see the rope.

TSERING
No. You saw what a corral looks like. A map is not what you expect to find. It is what is there.

The corrected sketch is a good deal better. He doesn't say so. She doesn't ask.

EXT. SCREE SLOPE ABOVE THE PEN - NIGHT

They crawl the last mile on their stomachs through scree that moves under them with every yard. The generator labors, muffled by snow. The fenced enclosure resolves into a pen thirty feet square, dug into the slope and shored with timber by someone who expects the walls to be tested.

Something inside it MOVES.

Indy goes still, the way he's learned to around animals that haven't decided whether to notice him.

A shape rises from the far timber. In the thin moonlight it stands taller than a man, considerably taller, shoulders too wide for the rest of it. One arm reaches up and closes around a fence timber, testing it. Feeling for give.

TSERING
(barely audible)
That is not an animal.

INDY
No.

TSERING
My brother's letters. The place the herders wouldn't graze.

Her voice has gone thin. Not fear exactly. More a woman finding out that a thing she has spent four years imagining is true.

TSERING (CONT'D)
He called it migoi. Wild man. I thought it was a story to keep children off dangerous ground.

The shape lets go of the timber. Draws something hard along the post, once. Sits back against the shoring.

For a moment, before it folds its arms across its knees, its face turns toward the dark where they lie. And something about the weight behind the eyes is close enough to a man looking at other men that the hair stands up on Indy's arms in a way four days of cold haven't managed.

A light comes on in the nearest tent. VOICES. A door flap scrapes.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Move.

EXT. OUTCROP ABOVE THE CAMP - LATER

A candle stub, burning too low to carry light. They've put a mile of broken ground behind them.

Around two in the morning Indy notices Tsering is shaking, steadily, and has been long enough to stop noticing. He takes off his sheepskin coat and puts it over her shoulders without a word. She lets him.

TSERING
You will freeze.

INDY
I've been colder. A mountain in Utah. A boy of fourteen, and a train.

He turns up his collar.

INDY (CONT'D)
It's a long story and I come off badly.

TSERING
Tell it.

INDY
Another time.

TSERING
There may not be another time.

But she doesn't push. He hears her breathing slow.

TSERING (CONT'D)
(much later, to the candle)
They found it in thirty-nine. Or they found proof of it. And Norbu knew. And four days before they left, my brother had an accident. I think Kessler has spent four years of a war wanting to come back and finish catching what my brother helped him find.

INDY
Then I need to know what Kessler thinks it is. I need his field reports.

He pinches out the candle.

INDY (CONT'D)
Every camp this size runs on local labor. Porters, cooks, men who carry water and don't ask questions. Somewhere down there is somebody who's had four years to start asking anyway.

TSERING
And if there isn't?

INDY
Then we find another way in. I didn't fly halfway around a war to turn back at a fence.

EXT. SCREE SLOPE - DUSK - NEXT DAY

Indy and Tsering lie flat behind a boulder, watching the camp. A slight figure in a quilted coat gone thin at the elbows comes up through the scree with both hands raised and empty, moving like someone who has rehearsed the approach.

Tsering has her knife out before Indy has his revolver. The man stops at twenty feet and says something in Tibetan, fast and low. Her shoulders come down an inch.

PEMBA
Pemba. I carry for the Germans. Water, wood, the heavy boxes. Four years, on and off.

INDY
Since before the war got to this part of the world.

PEMBA
Since before the pen.

That one word does more than a paragraph. He crouches on his heels and looks at Tsering longer than at Indy.

PEMBA (CONT'D)
You are Norbu's sister. I was there in thirty-nine. Not close to him at the end, but in the camp, the week it happened. I thought every year that someone should tell his family what the camp believed, even if it was a lie built to cover another lie.

TSERING
Tell me.

Her voice has none of its usual flatness. Thin and urgent, a rope pulled tighter than it was built for.

PEMBA
Not here.

He glances down the slope and goes flat. A PATROL TORCH is swinging across the scree below. Indy and Tsering are on their faces beside him before they've decided to be. Pemba finishes the rest of his plan into the dirt, in a whisper, while the beam crosses six feet over their heads.

PEMBA (CONT'D)
A supply train comes up from the lower depot in two days. Flour, kerosene, medical stores. I load it. I can hide one man among the crates, if he is small enough to fold and quiet enough to stay folded.

He measures Indy.

PEMBA (CONT'D)
You are not small. But you are the one who wants to read Kessler's papers, I think. Not just watch his fence from a rock.

INDY
How do you know what I want?

PEMBA
Because I have carried his papers for four years and never been permitted to read them. I am trusted to carry everything. I am trusted to see nothing.

INDY
What do you want for this?

Pemba looks at his hands.

PEMBA
My brother worked the depot road. Last September a German truck went off the switchback with crates that were not secured. My brother was walking beside it, because that was safer than riding on that grade. Except that day it was not. The camp paid his widow nothing. They said Tibetan roads were not their responsibility.

His jaw works.

PEMBA (CONT'D)
I want it written down, somewhere your government will read it, with his name spelled correctly. I have carried his name wrong on my own tongue for nine months, because the Germans never asked how to say it.

INDY
I can do that. More, if we get out with what I need.

PEMBA
Do not promise more than the first thing. I have had enough of men promising more than the first thing.

He stands.

PEMBA (CONT'D)
Come down after dark on the second night, where the trail forks below the big cairn. I will have a crate ready. It will not be comfortable.

INDY
I've ridden in worse.

PEMBA
Everyone says that. Until they try it.

EXT. RIDGE - NIGHT

A fire of yak dung that burns hot and smells like a barn. Tsering sharpens a knife that is already sharp.

TSERING
He could be Kessler's.

INDY
He could.

TSERING
A man who wants you to trust him will say he knew Norbu.

INDY
Yes.

TSERING
And you will go anyway.

INDY
If he's lying, I find out in a crate. If he's not, I find out in a tent. Either way I find out.

She doesn't argue. She measures out a box in stones on the ground, about the size of a coffin for a short man, and makes him practice.

INSERT - INDY FOLDING INTO THE STONE OUTLINE

He folds in. Folds out. She times him on his own watch.

TSERING (O.S.)
Again. You make the noise of a cow lying down.

By the eleventh try he can do it silently. On the twelfth he gets stuck, one knee behind his ear. She stands over him for a full minute considering the situation before she helps.

TSERING
Do not do that on the day.

She sheathes the knife, takes a length of red wool cord from her pack, knotted in two places, and ties it round his left wrist without asking. The knots are small and hard. She pulls each one until it bites.

INDY
What's it for?

TSERING
It is wool. It is warm.

She lets go.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Do not take it off in front of the Germans. They will want to look at it.

INT. SUPPLY CRATE - MOVING - DAY

Black. Cramped. Smells of kerosene and flour. Indy, folded into a space built for neither, listens to a mule's gait through inch-thick boards.

Two TAPS on the lid. Be still. Pemba, walking alongside, taps twice for most of the first hour, humming to the animals in a low flat tune, like a man talking to himself so he'll have something to say if anyone asks.

EXT. GERMAN CHECKPOINT - CONTINUOUS

A mule train halts. A GERMAN SERGEANT walks down the line of crates counting aloud.

SERGEANT
Fünfundvierzig. Sechsundvierzig.

He stops at a crate chalked 47. Loses his place. Starts again from the beginning, annoyed.

INT. SUPPLY CRATE - CONTINUOUS

Through a knothole Indy sees the next crate, chalked 47. He hears the count begin again, and hopes the man has a pencil.

INT. STORAGE TENT - SHOMO CAMP - DUSK

The crate is set down hard enough to jar his teeth. He lies still a long while. Then he works the lid loose with a knife blade and climbs out into the smell of every place he has ever hidden.

Pemba returns with a German greatcoat, too tight in the shoulders, the insignia picked off, the threads still showing.

PEMBA
From the laundry. A man who dies in the hospital tent does not need two.

The sleeves end an inch above Indy's wrist. The red cord shows. He turns his cuff down over it.

Through a gap in the tent flap, a slice of lit ground and the corner of the pen. A MAN IN A WHITE COAT crosses the gravel with a tin plate and a cup, a guard three paces behind. He sets the plate on a post by the wire, checks his watch, writes on a clipboard, and leaves.

For a minute nothing moves.

Then the shape rises from the shadows, comes to the wire, and takes the plate in both hands.

It eats carefully, with its fingers. When the plate is half empty, it stops. It pours the cup out onto the dirt, spoons the remaining rice into the empty cup with the edge of the plate, presses it down with a thumb, and carries it back into the dark.

Indy watches the place where it went. He couldn't say why that is the thing that stops his breath. It put something by. Whatever is in that pen is thinking about tomorrow.

PEMBA
Kessler's tent is third from the generator shed. He eats with the others at this hour every night, because he believes discipline is owed even to dinner. You have perhaps forty minutes.

INDY
And the pen?

PEMBA
Guarded always. I would not go near it tonight, American. Whatever Kessler writes in his tent, he has written already. Whatever is in that pen has not finished happening yet.

INDY
Forty minutes.

EXT. SHOMO CAMP - NIGHT

Indy crosses the camp in the dead man's coat with a crate of tin cans on his shoulder, which is the only disguise anyone has ever needed in any army. Nobody stops him.

The mess tent is lit and loud. Cards snap on a table. A BAVARIAN complains about lice in detail. Another man answers with a slow impression of an officer: "Kameraden. We are here to serve science." The tent roars. It takes Indy a moment to realize who is being mimicked. Not one of the generals.

Behind the mess tent, a clothesline holds three SS tunics, frozen stiff, arms out in the wind like men shot where they stood.

INT. KESSLER'S TENT - NIGHT

Bigger than the others. A surveyor's table taking up half of it, maps pinned under brass weights. A cot with hospital corners. A toothbrush standing in a tin cup. A jar of boiled sweets with the lid screwed down tight. A tray with one clean cup and one turned upside down, as if Kessler expects company and has decided the guest will be a neat one.

Everything is square to everything else. Indy knew men like this in graduate school. They were usually the ones who cried at the oral exams.

He goes straight to the trunk at the foot of the cot, because spies learn early that men hide their worst secrets at ankle height. Locked. A pick he's carried since Mexico opens it in thirty seconds.

Under a folded jacket with silver runes at the collar lies a leather folder stamped with the eagle and oak leaves.

He flips the pages. Skull indices, cheekbone breadth, the vocabulary of men who believed a brass caliper could sort humanity into what was worth keeping and what wasn't. Under the tables, photographs pasted to grid sheets: Tibetan men on the same stool against the same canvas wall, calipers at their temples, placards on their chests.

One stops him.

The man on the stool is about thirty. Broad-faced. A chipped front tooth. Under the placard, in pencil: N. Wangmo, guide. Spricht Englisch.

Indy doesn't take it. A missing photograph is a thing a man notices. He puts it back exactly as it was and tells himself to remember the number.

Further in, Kessler's handwriting loosens: a scientist writing for himself, not for Berlin. Indy reads, lips moving.

KESSLER (V.O.)
(precise, dry)
The 1939 expedition located skeletal fragments in the ice field above the camp, suggestive beyond any specimen catalogued by Western science. Local informants confirmed an oral tradition of a living population, consistent across three valleys with no contact between them. One living animal was taken in a snare on the night before the survey ended, and did not survive the night. I was prevented from completing the survey in 1939 by circumstances outside the expedition's control.

Indy reads the last phrase twice, the way he reads anything built to mean one thing on the surface and another underneath.

KESSLER (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Entry, 2 May. The specimen did not resist the net. It sat down in it. The men were disconcerted. I recorded the observation and instructed them not to repeat it in their reports.

He copies the two dated lines into his notebook, small and fast. The pencil snaps. He looks at the stub for half a second, then keeps the rest in his head, which is how he learned most of what he knows about the Sumerians.

BOOTS on gravel.

He drops the folder in the trunk, shuts the lid, pinches out the lamp, and slides under the cot, cheek on the boards, as the flap lifts. A flashlight beam crosses the tent at ankle height. A SOLDIER. His boots are polished, which means he was told to.

The beam sweeps the table. Moves across the floor to the dropped padlock. Stops.

Indy counts. One. Two. The beam wavers. A spider runs across the back of his hand. He allows it.

The soldier crosses to the table, unscrews the jar, takes out a sweet, puts it in his cheek. Whistles four bars through it. Leaves.

Indy lies there with his heart going. He snaps the padlock back on with fingers that won't stop shaking. Reopens the trunk. Gives himself two more pages.

KESSLER (V.O.)
The capture of a living specimen in April confirms what I observed in 1939. Preliminary examination suggests a surviving remnant population, exhibiting morphological characteristics that Reichsführer-SS Himmler's office will find of the highest interest. I have withheld full reporting to Berlin pending—

The flap moves.

Indy has time to drop the folder and get a hand on the lid before ERICH KESSLER steps inside: tall, younger than Indy pictured, pale eyes that take in the open trunk, the American beside it, and show none of the alarm the scene calls for.

KESSLER
You will be Jones. Please leave your hand where it is.

Indy's hand has been drifting toward his revolver. It stops. Two armed men now fill the flap behind Kessler, rifles up. The arithmetic does not favor drawing.

INDY
I was looking for the latrine.

KESSLER
In a locked trunk.

INDY
It's a big camp.

KESSLER
It is a very small camp, Dr. Jones. I had it surveyed.

He closes the trunk himself, gently.

KESSLER (CONT'D)
Stand, please. My men are young and nervous, and I would rather not explain a dead American professor to Berlin before I have finished explaining the living specimen.

Indy's revolver leaves his hip under a rifle muzzle and lands on the table with a sound too small for what it means to lose it.

The bullwhip follows. Kessler lifts it between two fingers like a specimen, lays it beside the revolver, and squares the pair to the table's edge.

Kessler doesn't sit. He goes round the tent putting right everything Indy touched, the trunk lid, the brass weights, the jar, like a man tidying after a burglary while delivering a speech he has rehearsed for months to an empty tent.

KESSLER (CONT'D)
I expected a thief. I did not expect to be glad of one. Berlin wants a root-race discovery, something Himmler can show the Führer. In Berlin's hands my specimen becomes a photograph, and then a skull in a case. What I lack is a credentialed scholar from outside the Reich who will examine him and put his name to what he is, somewhere Berlin cannot correct it. Someone is coming from Berlin to supervise me. I would like the question settled before he arrives.

Indy nudges a brass weight a quarter inch out of line. Kessler, mid-sentence, without looking, nudges it back.

INDY
You could have written to the Royal Asiatic Society.

KESSLER
I did. They replied they had no one qualified and did not care to be associated with the Institute.

He lifts his chin.

KESSLER (CONT'D)
I have also read your article on the Ur-Nammu tablets, Dr. Jones. Your second footnote is wrong. The sign is Old Babylonian, not Sargonic. It affects your whole argument.

INDY
You came three thousand miles to tell me my footnote's wrong?

KESSLER
I came for other reasons. The footnote I noticed on the voyage. I have had four years of men who nod when I speak.

There is no humor in it.

KESSLER (CONT'D)
I find it tiresome.

INDY
It's Sargonic.

KESSLER
It is not.

INDY
I'll send you a corrected copy, if we both live.

Kessler very nearly smiles. Then he sees that Indy has turned the jar a quarter turn, and the smile goes away.

INDY (CONT'D)
You want me to authenticate your Nazi science.

KESSLER
I want you to look at what is in that pen and tell me honestly, as the scholar you are rather than the soldier your government made of you this week, what you believe it to be. I think you will find the honest answer considerably more complicated than Berlin wants to hear.

He takes a boiled sweet from the jar and holds it out. Indy shakes his head.

KESSLER (CONT'D)
My sister sends them from Zurich once a month. She believes I am in the Black Forest studying moss. You may think what you like of me. I did not choose to be good at this.

INDY
You haven't tried. That's different.

Kessler sucks the sweet and says nothing. For a moment he looks like what he must have been at twelve: a boy who took a wrong turn into a book of birds.

INDY (CONT'D)
Does he have a name?

KESSLER
Specimens are catalogued by number.

INDY
Then you haven't asked.

KESSLER
I do not speak the language.

He squares the jar one last time and nods at the flap.

KESSLER (CONT'D)
Come. It is a short walk. The night air up here is quite bracing, once you have stopped minding the cold.

EXT. THE PEN - NIGHT

Kessler doesn't hurry. He takes a lantern from the guard at the tent door and carries it himself. The camp is nearly empty. Everyone who can be at dinner is at dinner.

The pen is bigger up close. Shoring as thick as a man's thigh, bolted at the corners with iron straps, a second line of wire along the top. Kessler raises the lantern and stands aside.

KESSLER
Do not go closer than the wire.

INDY
I wasn't planning to.

KESSLER
Of course. Look, please.

It sits against the far timber with its knees drawn up. Taller than a man, wide through the shoulder, covered everywhere but the face and palms in reddish-brown hair.

The face is what Indy braced for, and it still gets past him. It isn't a man's face and it isn't an animal's. Heavy brow. Deep-set eyes. Mouth shut tight. It looks at the lantern, then at Indy, with an attention he has seen on exactly one other kind of face: a patient in a long ward who has stopped expecting anyone to explain.

KESSLER (CONT'D)
Tell me what you see.

INDY
A prisoner.

KESSLER
That is not an anatomical description.

INDY
It's the only one I'm sure of. How long have you had it in that hole?

KESSLER
Seven weeks. He eats well. We have given him a roof for the rain.

He. Kessler said it the way you say it about a dog you've decided to like. Indy lets it go by, because his eyes have found something on the nearest post, at the height of a seated man's reach.

Scratches. Deep, made with something hard. They run in groups of five: four short strokes and a long one across. Row under row.

He counts. Forty-nine.

Groups of five. Four short strokes and one long across. He has seen that tally before, cut into a stone two days below the pass, under a thousand years of lichen. Why count a border? To know when someone crosses. He had thought she meant people.

Kessler follows his look. When he speaks it isn't in the voice he used in the tent.

KESSLER (CONT'D)
I told the guards it was random. A habit. Sharpening claws. I have not been able to make myself believe that for some weeks.

INDY
Seven weeks is forty-nine days. He's counting.

KESSLER
Or marking something. I would much rather have a man who is not on my payroll tell me it means nothing.

Indy looks at the tally for a long time. His eye slides down the post to the pen's lower corner, where an iron strap runs across the shoring, held by four bolts. Two of the bolt heads are bright where the paint has worn, as though someone has been handling them.

He notes it and moves on, because he is looking at a man's count of his own captivity and couldn't look at anything else.

Behind the wire the creature has put its chin on its knees and is no longer watching either of them.

INDY
I can't tell you that.

KESSLER
No. I was afraid not.

INT. SUPPLY TENT - NIGHT

Guarded, but not mistreated. Kessler still has a use for him. Around midnight the guard at the flap, a kid of eighteen with a scab on his chin, brings in a tin of cold stew, sets it on a crate, and doesn't leave.

YOUNG GUARD
Herr Professor. You have seen the snow-man?

INDY
I've seen a lot of snow.

YOUNG GUARD
No. The man. Hauptmann says it is a bear. Corporal Meyer says it is a man in a skin. A prisoner. He says the Hauptmann is lying.

INDY
What do you say?

The boy looks at the stew, the flap, Indy.

YOUNG GUARD
I say I would like to go home. I say it is very big.

INDY
Eat your stew.

It was Indy's own stew. The boy, to his own visible surprise, does.

EXT. SHOMO CAMP - DAWN

They let him go at first light on Kessler's instruction: the Herr Professor is to go away and think, and come back when he has.

On his way out, the MESS COOK, a stout man with a pipe and no apparent interest in the war, steps from his tent and puts a heel of black bread in Indy's hand. He says something in German. Indy takes it for a blessing, or a complaint about the bread.

EXT. SLOPE ABOVE THE CAMP - CONTINUOUS

Halfway up, Indy hears the DOG. A big yellow mongrel on a lead, coming down the track with a SERGEANT and a PRIVATE behind it. There is no cover but one shoulder-high rock. He gets behind it and lies still.

The dog stops. Lifts its head. Turns, with the calm of an animal that has found the interesting thing, toward the rock.

SERGEANT
Was ist?

Indy tears the bread in half and tosses it six feet to the side. The dog goes after it. The private laughs, tired, and says the cook's bread is good enough for a dog and not for a soldier.

The dog looks back at the rock, plainly unfinished. Indy throws the second half.

The sergeant looks at the dog. At the bread. For one second, directly at the rock. Indy sees the gray in his stubble.

Then he looks away.

SERGEANT (CONT'D)
Komm.

Quite gently. The patrol goes on down toward the camp.

It's the second time in a day that someone in that camp has decided not to see him. He doesn't know what to do with the fact.

EXT. RIDGE ABOVE SHOMO - DAY

Tsering is waiting, three days of watching having worn a groove of worry into a face that doesn't usually show much.

TSERING
You're alive.

From her, it is close to an embrace.

He tells her everything on the climb back. The trunk. The report. Kessler's offer. The unfinished sentence. The tallies. She mends his sheepskin coat on her knee while he talks, with a bone needle, and the needle goes in a little harder with each piece of news. At Kessler's offer it goes through the cloth and into her thumb. She sucks it, unbothered, and keeps sewing.

The photograph he tells last, because it is the only thing he isn't sure she'll want.

TSERING
Say the name under it.

INDY
N. Wangmo. Guide. Speaks English.

TSERING
Did he have a tooth gone? On the left, in front.

INDY
Yes.

She nods slowly and says nothing for a long time. A RAVEN lands on the rock above them, looks, and leaves.

TSERING
He learned English from a missionary who was kind to him. He was proud of it. I used to tell him his accent was a joke.

She picks a thread from her sleeve.

TSERING (CONT'D)
I would like to see the picture. When this is finished.

INDY
If I can get it.

TSERING
You will not. Men like Kessler keep what they take. But I would like to see it.

INDY
"Circumstances outside the expedition's control." He didn't finish the sentence before he caught me. I think it's Norbu.

TSERING
Don't.

It comes out sharp, a blade drawn fast.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Do not tell me what I know, American. You have been in this valley six days. I have carried this four years.

INDY
Then help me finish it. Norbu's last letter. The one before the news.

TSERING
There was not a last letter.

Too fast.

INDY
Tsering.

The wind rattles the prayer flags behind them. She fights something out on her own face she would plainly have preferred to fight in private. Indy says, before she can speak:

INDY (CONT'D)
I pushed too hard. You don't owe me Norbu.

TSERING
No. I don't.

She pulls her coat tighter, though the cold isn't why.

TSERING (CONT'D)
There was a letter. Not through the trading company's post. A porter leaving the expedition two weeks early brought it to me. I have had it four years. I have read it exactly once.

INDY
Why once?

TSERING
Because once was enough.

From an inner pocket sewn with a lifetime of careful mending she draws a folded square of paper gone soft and gray at the creases.

TSERING (CONT'D)
I was going to burn it. A dozen times. I never did. I don't know why.

INDY
You know why.

TSERING
Yes.

She holds it out. Her hand doesn't shake, which costs her more than if it had.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Read it to me. Every time I try, the Tibetan runs together and I can't make the letters stay in order. He wrote half of it in English, the half he wanted the Germans not to understand if it was searched.

Indy unfolds it with the care he gives anything old.

NORBU (V.O.)
(warm, quick, a man writing against the clock)
Sister, I am writing this quickly and giving it to a man leaving tonight whom I trust more than the post. They found bones in the ice above the camp three weeks ago. Kessler has not told the others everything he believes about them. I helped him dig.

FLASHBACK - EXT. ICE FIELD ABOVE SHOMO - NIGHT (1939)

Blue-black moonlight on ice. NORBU WANGMO, thirty-one, broad-faced, a chipped front tooth, crouches behind a ridge. Below him, a YOUNGER KESSLER and two men, LANG and BRENNER, set snares meant for something larger than any animal in these mountains.

NORBU (V.O.)
Two nights ago I followed him and two of his men past the ice field after dark. I watched them set snares meant for something larger than any animal I know in these mountains. I did not understand until I saw what came into one before dawn, crying out in a voice with words in it, or close enough to words that no man who heard it could call it only an animal.

Norbu's face, white in the dark. He does not look afraid. He looks like a man about to laugh at something terrible.

Below him, Kessler turns. Looks straight up the slope. Straight at him.

NORBU (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Kessler saw me watching. He has changed toward me, as you do toward someone you cannot afford to trust. I will try to leave early, on the excuse of a family matter. If something happens to me before I can, know that I did not fall on any slope I did not know by heart. Know that whatever they tell you, it was not the mountain that—

CUT BACK TO:

EXT. RIDGE ABOVE SHOMO - DAY

The letter stops there.

Not a trailing thought. The pen simply came off the page, the last word cut at its first stroke. Beneath it, a long tear runs up from the bottom edge, old and soft and brown, where the page has been folded and unfolded so many times along exactly that line that it has finally given way.

INDY
(quietly)
It was the mountain that. He never finished it.

TSERING
I have known what the next word was for four years.

When her voice breaks, it breaks the way ice breaks on a lake in spring, all at once, with a sound that carries farther than either of them expects.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Killed. It was the mountain that killed him. And it was Kessler who decided the mountain would.

EXT. ROCK OVERHANG - NIGHT

A small fire, risked in the lee of the boulders. Tsering sits with Norbu's letter in her lap, not looking at it. When she speaks, her voice has gone back to the flat control Indy first heard in Rateng, as though what broke earlier was a door that opened once and shut itself hard behind her.

TSERING
Kessler is down there sleeping in that tent with his unfinished sentences. I want to go down tonight and put a knife in him and leave before anyone finds him.

INDY
If you do, the specimen stays in that pen. Kessler's report gets finished by someone just as willing to write it, with less conscience about it. I promise you that's possible. I've met the type.

He keeps his voice level.

INDY (CONT'D)
Your brother's letter doesn't end with Kessler dead in his tent. It ends with the truth getting out. And if you go down that slope tonight, the only one who dies for certain is you.

She doesn't answer right away. Far down the valley a dog or a wolf begins a long rising call that nobody answers.

TSERING
I am not leaving. Whatever you think I decided, deciding not to put a knife in a sleeping man is not the same as being finished. I am not leaving this valley until that man answers for what he did, in words, in front of someone who can make it matter.

INDY
I know.

TSERING
Good.

She lies down at last, not next to him but near enough that her back is to his, the single blanket stretched across them both like a bad treaty.

TSERING (CONT'D)
(into the dark)
The woman on the dock. In your other country. Did you keep your promise?

INDY
Part of it. I told her the truth. I didn't do it fast enough.

TSERING
That is the part you break most often. Men tell the truth when it is too late to be used.

INDY
I'll try to do better.

TSERING
You will not. But you will notice. That is something.

The blanket slips. She pulls it back over his shoulder without turning around. Neither of them mentions it.

EXT. RIDGE - DAWN

Gray light, no warmth. Tsering makes tea on a flame the size of a thumb.

INDY
What's in it?

TSERING
Tea. Butter. Salt. Yak. It is better hot. Hold your nose.

INDY
Is that what you do?

TSERING
I was raised on it.

She almost smiles.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Norbu held his nose for the first year. He said it was like drinking a candle.

Indy drinks. It is like drinking a candle. He gets it down in three swallows and sits with his eyes watering while she watches with something he'd call enjoyment in anyone else.

TSERING (CONT'D)
He cooked badly. He could walk ten days over ice on a broken toe and not complain, and he could not boil water without burning it. Our father said he would starve in any country with a stove. He sang, too. Always the same song, the wrong tune. I used to throw my shoe at him.

INDY
Did you hit him?

TSERING
Every time. He had a very large head.

She tips the dregs onto the stones.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Finish. We are not going to sit in the cold being sad for him. He would have laughed at us.

Hurried footsteps on scree. PEMBA, out of breath, moving faster than Indy has ever seen him move. Indy is cycling the bolt of Tsering's father's LEE-ENFIELD, her hand over his, and she doesn't let him stop.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Keep going. He can talk to your back.

PEMBA
Berlin. A signal came in last night. Someone is coming to take charge, and the extraction is moved forward. There is a landing strip two valleys east, where the Luftwaffe has been flying in supplies. They will fly the specimen and the reports out in two days, not two weeks.

His hands won't stay still.

PEMBA (CONT'D)
And Kessler has ordered the rocket troop reactivated. The ones with the harness packs. I did not know we had such men until this morning. They were kept in a separate tent near the shed, and I was told never to go near it.

The bolt slams home with a CLACK like a dropped plate. Tsering raps Indy's knuckles.

TSERING
Slowly.

INDY
(working the bolt, gently now)
The ones from the plane. Or more of them.

PEMBA
Eight men came out of that tent carrying equipment I had never seen. Kessler watched them looking pleased for the first time. The young one in charge was whistling. He asked whether the mountain behind the valley had a name in my language. I told him. Lhari. He said it back correctly. He was polite.

He looks at Indy as though that were the worst part.

PEMBA (CONT'D)
They are all so polite.

Tsering takes the rifle back.

TSERING
If you do it fast, it speaks. If you do it slowly, it only breathes.

INDY
Why not take your own rifle?

TSERING
It is the only thing of my father's that Norbu did not want. He said it kicked too hard. He said it was not a gun for a man who talks to mules. You will never use it. But you will know how it sounds when someone else does.

EXT. DRY LAKE BED - THE AIRSTRIP - DAY

A long scrape of gravel on a dry lake bed. A flour sack on a pole for a windsock. At the near end, nose to the wind, a JUNKERS 52 with the swastika on its tail painted over in a gray that doesn't quite take. Petrol drums stacked in rows beside it. Six men in sheepskins smoke on top of them.

Indy and Tsering watch from a gully above.

TSERING
Burn it?

INDY
Then Kessler sends for another and moves the clock up even more.

He counts the men. Six. The drums. Forty-one.

INDY (CONT'D)
We don't touch it. We just need to know it's there.

They've been watching an hour when the sound begins: a high thin SCREAMING, far off. He knows it before he knows he knows it. He rolls onto his back.

Two shapes are coming over the eastern ridge, low, trailing flame, following their own tracks in the shale.

TSERING
Run.

INDY
They can fly. We can't run. But we can pick where.

A cut in the shale wall forty yards south, six feet wide, a ledge leaning over it like a shelf.

He takes her arm. They go down in a rattle of loose stone and slide under the overhang with the rifle between them as the flames come on.

EXT. THE GULLY - CONTINUOUS

The rocket troopers HOVER above the gully, their harnesses shrieking. Heat drips meltwater off the rock onto Indy's neck.

He puts his watch face up on his knee and begins to count.

INDY
(whispering)
I read the bulletin in London. Ninety seconds at full climb. A hover burns faster.

TSERING
What?

INDY
I'm counting.

A boot comes down past the lip. Then a leg. Then gloved hands working a valve. Tsering's rifle comes up. Indy puts his palm on the barrel and pushes it down. She gives him a look of pure fury. He shakes his head once.

Twenty seconds. Forty. A gout of fire comes down the gully and the shale cracks. Sixty. A tongue of flame licks along the overhang an arm's length from his head. Seventy. Eighty. He can smell burning leather.

He finds, to his surprise, that he is praying.

Ninety-three seconds.

The second pack COUGHS: an ugly stutter in the fire. The trooper drops six feet, catches himself, drops again. The first swings wildly to help. Both go away over the ridge in a spiral of black smoke, shouting. A moment later comes a distant crash, and then nothing.

Tsering lowers the rifle. She is breathing through her teeth.

TSERING
How did you know?

INDY
I read a bulletin.

TSERING
A paper.

She says it as though he'd pulled a coin from behind her ear.

TSERING (CONT'D)
You counted. You waited. With a rifle on my knee.

INDY
That's what I do. I read things and then I get lucky.

TSERING
It is not luck to count.

She slaps shale from her coat.

TSERING (CONT'D)
Eight who fly. Six, now. They will be back with more.

INDY
We can't take on the camp.

TSERING
We do not need to take it. We need to be inside for as long as it takes to do one thing. Two days. Then they fly out, and my brother's name is a hole in the ground.

From the valley, faint and regular, the sound of mule bells. Indy realizes he's counting them without meaning to, the way a man counts the ticks of a clock in a sickroom.

INDY
Two days.

EXT. RIDGE ABOVE SHOMO - NEXT DAY

Tsering shaves Indy with her knife, on the theory that a man who walks into a German camp looking like a yak will be shot like one. Pemba watches the camp through field glasses.

PEMBA
Albrecht Voss. Four soldiers, a wireless set, and a case marked FRAGILE that three men had to carry. A porter asked what was in it. A soldier said, very quietly, "Records." The camp calls him the Doctor from Berlin, though nobody knows what he is a doctor of.

INDY
Administration. Every institute like Kessler's has one. Somebody who signs the checks and reads the reports Kessler would rather not write.

PEMBA
Since he came, nothing is the way it was. He sent back the water because it was not boiled twice. He sent back the bed. He has a gramophone, and in the evening he plays a man singing, very slowly, very sad. The soldiers hate it. Kessler asked him to stop and he said Kessler's authority did not extend to the acoustics of the officers' quarters.

INDY
He said that?

PEMBA
In the passive voice.

He looks pleased, and a little ashamed to be pleased.

PEMBA (CONT'D)
I did not know there was a way to be angry at a man in the passive voice. It is very effective. Nobody could tell who it was meant for.

Indy laughs. Tsering's knife nicks him.

TSERING
Hold still.

No sympathy at all.

INDY
I want to know what Berlin actually wants from this valley. I don't think it's what Kessler wants. A crack like that is usually the only door worth walking through.

TSERING
You are going to walk in the front door.

INDY
The side door. North perimeter.

TSERING
That is a door.

She turns to Pemba. They trade a few lines in Tibetan in which Indy catches the word for bell.

PEMBA
The cook rings the dinner bell at seven. She says if you are not out of the camp by the seventh bell, she will come in after you.

INDY
She'll be shot.

PEMBA
She says yes. She says it is not a threat. It is a schedule.

INDY
Seventh bell. Don't be early.

TSERING
I will be exactly on time. You will be the one who is late.

EXT. SHOMO CAMP - NORTH PERIMETER - DUSK

Indy walks in alone, no crate this time, hands visible. A GUARD challenges him forty feet in and marches him at rifle point toward the largest tent, which tells him Voss's arrival has changed the camp's rules on what a wandering American is worth shooting over.

They take his belt, his pocketknife, and the red cord from his wrist. A young CORPORAL turns the cord over twice, shrugs, and hands it back as if it were a child's toy.

INT. VOSS'S TENT - DUSK

Warm. A real iron stove, a kettle, and real coffee, not the roasted acorn the Reich has been drinking for two years. Somebody flew it in, deciding a man from Berlin was worth the weight. On the camp table, turned so the man in the chair can see it, stands a photograph of a plump woman in a hat with two small girls.

VOSS (O.S.)
Kuhn. The ribbon is in the second drawer, not the first. It was in the second drawer yesterday.

A CORPORAL named KUHN at the door flinches, closes his ledger, and shows Indy in with the face of a man who spends most of his day being corrected.

ALBRECHT VOSS is already on his feet, in his coat, with a clipboard: fifties, thinning hair combed flat, the unhurried patience of someone who has spent a career outlasting more excitable men. He doesn't offer his hand.

VOSS
Walk with me, Dr. Jones. I inspect at dusk, and I will not be late on account of a visitor.

He's through the flap before Indy can answer, Kuhn trotting behind with the ledger.

EXT. SHOMO CAMP - CONTINUOUS

The strangest interrogation Indy has ever sat through, because nobody sits. Voss marches him across the camp at a clip and conducts his business and Indy's at once.

He stops at a sentry with an open top button. "Name." Writes it down. Says nothing else, which turns the sentry the color of a boiled ham. He kicks a tent peg. It holds. He looks faintly disappointed.

VOSS
Kessler speaks of you with professional respect, which from him is rare. He believes you are the only man within a thousand miles qualified to confirm his findings. I read his summary. It had a typographical error on page four, in the word "skeletal." A man who cannot control his typists cannot control a specimen.

INDY
I've formed an opinion of what's in that pen.

VOSS
You imagine Berlin wants proof. A living ancestor. That is Kessler's dream.

He says it flatly, without the caution Indy would expect under a regime that punishes frankness.

VOSS (CONT'D)
Berlin's dream is winning a war it is no longer certain of winning. I require a specimen photogenic enough for a headline and a report clean enough that no journalist can prove it a fraud. What I will not permit to leave this valley is a complication.

INDY
Like a dead guide in nineteen thirty-nine.

Voss's face doesn't move, which is its own kind of answer. He stops at a sagging guy rope, thrusts the clipboard at Indy, "Hold this," and kneels to retie the knot, muttering.

VOSS
Kessler's methods in thirty-nine were his own affair. If a guide died inconveniently four years ago, that is a matter for Kessler's conscience, assuming he retains one, and not for any report bearing my signature. I have no interest in unburying it, which amounts to the same practical result.

Indy, who was raised never to pass an unguarded pencil, slides the one from under the clip up his sleeve.

VOSS (CONT'D)
I would also prefer that you did not.

He rises and takes back the clipboard.

VOSS (CONT'D)
A dead expedition member interests nobody. An American professor found dead in a ravine, working for an intelligence service your own newspapers would be delighted to name, interests a great many people.

He pats his pockets. Frowns.

VOSS (CONT'D)
Kuhn. A pencil.

Kuhn produces one. Indy keeps his face as plain as he can.

EXT. THE PEN - CONTINUOUS

They've come to the pen. The guards snap to attention. Inside, the specimen sits with its chin on its knees and watches Voss with polite, patient disinterest, like a man at the opera who's paid for worse seats.

Voss's hand goes to his breast pocket and stays there.

VOSS
Do you have children, Dr. Jones?

INDY
No.

VOSS
Then you are freer than I am. I have two girls, six and eight. They wanted to know what a yeti is. I said I would find out. I would like to go home and tell them it is a kind of goat.

It is the least official thing he's said. It is also the most frightening, because Indy understands that Voss means every word and that none of it will change a single order he gives.

VOSS (CONT'D)
Walk away tonight. Take your guide and whatever grief she carries. The thing in that pen becomes a photograph, then a specimen in a case, then a curiosity nobody remembers.

INDY
He's marking the days on the fence post. Forty-nine when I counted. Fifty-two by now.

VOSS
Who is?

INDY
Your photograph.

Voss looks at the post. He looks at the creature, which looks back.

VOSS
I will have it sanded.

He makes a note with Kuhn's pencil.

VOSS (CONT'D)
Your answer, Dr. Jones?

INDY
No.

Voss nods, as at a figure he had expected.

VOSS
Then I regret that our walk has been a waste of good lamp oil. Guards. See Dr. Jones to the perimeter. Gently, for now.

EXT. SHOMO CAMP - DUSK

They walk him out through a camp that has begun to smell of onions: two guards and a rifle at his back. Men drift toward the mess tent in twos and threes. At the bell the whole camp will empty into it, as it does every night, and the only ones left outside will be the two at the pen, who have been told the lion is asleep.

His escort is FELDWEBEL STOLL, a face like a closed door and Indy's own belt looped over one shoulder like a bandolier. Three paces behind, the YOUNG GUARD with the scab on his chin carries his rifle like a broom.

Voss gave the order in the passive voice. Nobody could have said whom it was meant for. Stoll, Indy gathers, has decided it was meant for him.

STOLL
The Herr Doktor said perimeter.

INDY
He said gently, too.

STOLL
Yes.

He weighs the sentence.

STOLL (CONT'D)
To shoot is not gentle. It is loud.

He points past the mess tent, past the clothesline where three frozen tunics stand stiff in the dusk, to where the camp ends in a cut of broken ground.

STOLL (CONT'D)
A man falls. It is very quiet.

INDY
That's one reading.

STOLL
It is the only reading.

He takes hold of him.

EXT. BEHIND THE MESS TENT - CONTINUOUS

Indy has been in a fair number of fights and has never won one by being polite. He drives an elbow into Stoll's ribs, which is like elbowing a sack of coal. Stoll answers with a fist that puts him through the CLOTHESLINE.

The line goes, and the frozen tunics with it, landing across Indy's chest with the weight of fresh lumber. He rolls, comes up with one by the collar, and swings. The sleeves are stiff as oars. It takes Stoll across the side of the head with a sound like a door slammed in a cellar, and the big man sits down in the mud with a look of honest surprise.

And then gets up again, because he is a Feldwebel.

YOUNG GUARD
(raising his rifle, no idea what to do with it)
Please. Please, I do not—

INDY
Stay there.

He ducks a swing that would have taken his ear. Goes round the pole. Catches his own belt where it hangs over Stoll's shoulder and pulls. It isn't a whip. The whip is in a trunk across the camp, which is the sort of thing Indy intends to take up with the universe later. It's a belt with a brass buckle. But Indy has spent twenty years learning what to do with a length of leather, and his wrist knows before he does. The buckle flicks round Stoll's forearm and bites. Indy heaves. The Feldwebel leaves his feet, and then, with the enormous stubborn dignity of a man who has never been dragged anywhere, gets back onto them and wraps both arms round Indy's chest.

STOLL
(almost kindly)
It is quiet.

He begins to walk.

Indy's boots leave the ground. The edge is ten yards off. Eight. He can smell the old blue cold rising out of the cut. He hammers at Stoll's ears with the buckle. He might as well hammer at a church.

Across the camp, a single BELL begins to ring.

Stoll takes another step.

And out of the dark behind the generator shed comes a noise like someone beating a carpet with a coal scuttle.

A MULE, at full gallop. Not graceful. A mule does not gallop so much as conduct a long serious argument with the ground, at speed, and lose none of it. It bursts out of the dusk with its ears flat, and low along its neck, hair loose, gripping a Lee-Enfield by the barrel like an axe handle, rides TSERING.

The mule passes Stoll's backside at about eleven miles an hour.

It is the honest gray, who has bitten everyone who ever stood behind it, and who now finds himself running for the first time in his career directly at a man's rear end with full permission.

The bell covers most of what Stoll says. He lets go. Indy hits the ground. Tsering is off the mule before it stops. The rifle butt comes round in a short flat arc. Stoll sits down for the second time that evening and stays there, with a neat double row of tooth marks through the seat of his trousers and an expression of profound betrayal.

The Young Guard has raised both hands without being asked. His lips are moving.

YOUNG GUARD
Ich will—

He tries it in English.

YOUNG GUARD (CONT'D)
I would like to go home.

INDY
I know. Sit down.

He buckles his belt back on.

INDY (CONT'D)
Tie him. Make it tight.

YOUNG GUARD
Tight. Please. They will ask.

She uses the mule's lead rope, with five small hard knots exactly like the ones in the red cord on Indy's wrist, and sits the boy against the clothesline pole. From the mess tent comes a roar of laughter and the Bavarian voice doing his slow impression: "Kameraden. We are here to serve science." Nobody comes out to see about a bell, a mule, or a man in the mud.

The boy shuts his eyes and begins to whistle softly through his teeth, like a person who has heard absolutely nothing.

Tsering looks at Indy, at the wrecked clothesline, at three frozen tunics lying in the mud with their arms still raised, and at the bell, which has just stopped.

TSERING
Seven.

INDY
It's seven. I was on my way out.

TSERING
You were on your way over a cliff.

She swings back onto the mule, which stands for it.

TSERING (CONT'D)
You are late. Get up.

INDY
On that?

TSERING
It is the fastest thing I had.

Indy, who once outran a boulder in Peru, climbs up behind her without another word. They go out through the north perimeter at a bone-rattling trot, into a sky just going dark, to the sound of a mess tent laughing at a man who isn't there.

EXT. RIDGE ABOVE SHOMO - NIGHT

They're back on the ridge within the hour. Indy tells Pemba what Voss offered and what he refused.

PEMBA
Two days becomes one. I heard it from the cook. Voss wants the specimen crated and the camp broken by tomorrow night.

INDY
Then we move tonight. Before they're ready for us instead of after. I don't need to steal the creature yet. I need Kessler's report before it's crated onto that plane with Voss's signature on the cover. Once it reaches Berlin, there's no pulling it back out.

TSERING
And Norbu? Does the report matter more than that?

INDY
No. But they're the same fight now. Kessler wrote enough in that trunk to hang himself on both counts, if it reaches the right hands instead of Berlin's.

Tsering passes round a tin of lamp soot. They blacken their faces. Indy's comes out streaky.

TSERING
You look like a man who lost a fight with a chimney.

She fixes it with her thumb, hard, the way she tightens a pack strap.

Pemba draws in the dirt with a stick. A line for the north edge, a square for the generator shed, a circle for the pen.

PEMBA
Voss has doubled the guard. Kessler's trunk was in his tent. Today I saw it carried out and put by the mule line. Two of Voss's men carried it, not like a trunk. Like a coffin.

He looks at Indy.

PEMBA (CONT'D)
I tell you so you will know it may be locked.

INDY
It was locked last time.

PEMBA
It was. You opened it.

He rubs out the circle with his boot.

PEMBA (CONT'D)
Please do it again, but faster.

INDY
I'll do my best.

PEMBA
You said that last time also.

For the first time since Indy met him, Pemba smiles, thinly, and doesn't seem to enjoy it.

Tsering oils the Lee-Enfield with a rag from her sleeve.

TSERING
If I fall, you will not carry me.
You will carry the paper.

INDY
I'll carry both.

TSERING
You are a poor liar, and a worse
mule.

She slides the bolt home and listens to it, the small final sound of a good lock.

TSERING (CONT'D)
I have decided you are not
completely useless.

Pemba holds out a twist of paper: dried apricots, black and hard as buttons.

PEMBA
For afterward. A man who has been
afraid should eat something sweet.

INDY
Where did you get these?

PEMBA
The quartermaster's tent. I have
carried his boxes for four years. I
decided I was owed.

Indy eats one. It tastes of sunlight and a very long time ago.

INDY
(to Tsering)
That's the nicest thing you've said to me.

TSERING
Do not get used to it.

EXT. THE SLOPE ABOVE THE CAMP - AFTER MIDNIGHT

They go down the way she taught him: low and slow over ground that punishes haste. They're in sight of the generator shed when a HAND closes on Pemba's shoulder out of the dark.

A voice barks something in German that needs no translation.

Indy and Tsering go flat. Pemba doesn't run. He stands very still as a torch finds his face. Two of Voss's men march him toward the lit tents, shoulders set in the posture of a man who has decided how much truth to spend keeping two other people alive.

Tsering comes up onto one knee. Indy catches her round the waist with one arm and clamps the other hand over her mouth. She drives an elbow into his ribs. Again. The second he feels in his teeth. She bites the heel of his hand through the glove and he makes a sound he's glad the wind takes.

INDY
(barely a breath,
against her ear)
Tsering. If you go, he's wasted.

She says something into his palm in Tibetan. He doesn't need a translator. She keeps saying it until the torch swings away. Then she stops all at once and lies with her breath hissing through her nose.

He takes his hand off her mouth. There's blood on it. He isn't sure whose.

She doesn't apologize. She wipes her chin on her sleeve and looks at the camp.

TSERING
Move.

INT. VOSS'S TENT - NIGHT (INTERCUT)

Pemba, questioned hard enough to leave marks that will take weeks to fade, tells Voss's men the Americans plan to strike at dawn, and that the target is the pen. It is a lie with just enough detail to survive a first round of questioning and just enough wrongness to buy two people a window.

EXT. SCREE SLOPE - CONTINUOUS

A ROCKET TROOPER lands on the scree thirty feet from them and stands up. Indy gets his first look at the man inside the harness.

Very young. The leather helmet has slipped off his forehead. His face is white and wet. He is working the valve on his left cylinder with a shaking thumb, the way a boy works a stuck bicycle chain.

He sees them. He stops.

Tsering has the Lee-Enfield at her shoulder before Indy finishes turning. The boy raises his hands. For two seconds nobody breathes.

Then a voice from the camp shouts "BRANDT!" and the boy's face closes. His thumb finds the valve.

She shoots the cylinder, not the man.

The pack goes up with a BANG like a door slammed in a cathedral. Brandt falls on his back in the scree with his hands over his face, alive, swearing quietly in German, the same word over and over, while the dark fills with light.

TSERING
I did not want to kill him.

INDY
I know.

TSERING
(working the bolt)
I would have. Move.

EXT. THE MULE LINE - NIGHT

The one part of the camp nobody thinks could be a target. Under a tarp at the foot of a stack of big boxes, exactly where Pemba said, sits the trunk. Two of Voss's men guard it from crates, sharing a cigarette.

Indy holds up two fingers. Tsering goes around the end of the line with the Lee-Enfield held by the barrel, moving as slowly as she taught him to cycle the bolt, and clips the nearer guard below the ear. The other stands up. Indy, who has picked up a tin lid without quite deciding to, hits him with that.

It isn't dignified. It takes four seconds. The cigarette is still burning when they drag both men behind the crates.

The lock is the same lock. He has it open in twenty seconds, a personal best.

The leather folder lies on top, under the jacket with the runes. And beneath it, wrapped in a pair of Kessler's clean socks, his own revolver, and in a second pair, coiled like something asleep, the whip.

He hangs the whip back on his belt. It feels like finding a shoe he's been missing for a week. He slides the folder into a canvas satchel one guard was using as a pillow and hangs it across his chest.

Then a SHOT whistles past his ear, close enough to move his hair.

EXT. SHOMO CAMP - CONTINUOUS

FLOODLIGHTS blaze across the camp, powered by the shed he's been counting on for dark. Men pour from the tents half-dressed. From the separate tent comes the low catching roar he last heard over Biscay.

Two harness troopers go up in a spray of fire and gravel and hang over the pen, turning, their flames throwing the valley into hard orange and black. When their packs cough they drop to the drums by the shed, take fresh charges, and go up again. The sky is never empty.

TSERING
Down!

She has him by the collar. They go flat behind the crates as rifle fire stitches the tarp.

Indy lies with his cheek in the dirt. Across forty yards of lit ground he can see the pen. Everyone in the camp is looking at the sky.

The creature isn't.

It stands in the back corner of the pen, where the iron strap runs across the timber, with both hands on the strap. It isn't pulling. It is standing quite calmly with its face turned up into the floodlights, like a man waiting for a train to pass before he crosses.

Two bolts on the strap are bright where the paint has worn. He noticed that three nights ago and filed it, the way you file what you've been trained not to follow.

INDY
He doesn't need to get out. He needs it dark.

TSERING
What?

INDY
Fifty-two nights. He's been working those bolts a quarter turn at a time, and he's been waiting for the lights to go out.

It comes to him whole, the way a translation does after a day of pushing at it.

INDY (CONT'D)
I can't kill the floodlights from here. I need the shed. Which means I need the camp out of the way.

He points at the line of animals along the rope, forty of them, rolling their eyes at the fire overhead.

INDY (CONT'D)
How fast can you cut those loose?

Tsering looks at the mules. At the tents.

Then she does something he has never seen her do. She laughs, one hard bark, and draws her knife.

EXT. THE MULE LINE - CONTINUOUS

She goes down the picket line in one pull. The rope parts at every post. Forty frightened animals discover, in the same second, that they are free and the sky is on fire.

They go through the camp like water through a broken dam.

The mess tent folds under them. The big tent follows, and from inside comes a thin strangled shout that sounds, absurdly, like a man calling for his records. A cook goes over a drum of kerosene and comes up swearing in Bavarian. Tsering fires the Lee-Enfield into the air; the rear of the herd turns toward the noise, the front toward the lights, and the whole screaming mass sweeps across the open ground with Voss's guards diving left and right.

Indy runs in their lee, the satchel against his chest and a mule's flank two feet from his shoulder. When the herd bends toward the pen he cuts left and reaches the shed door.

INT. GENERATOR SHED - CONTINUOUS

A MECHANIC stands with a spanner raised and the stunned look of a man who came out to see about a noise. CRACK. The whip takes the spanner out of his hand and sets it on the floor like a retriever. Indy hits him in the stomach, harder than he means to, and steps over him.

The generator is a squat diesel under a tin roof. A black rubber fuel line runs from a drum to the injector.

He cuts it clean through.

Fuel sprays his hands. The engine coughs. Coughs again, a long sick sound. And quits.

Every floodlight in the valley goes out together.

EXT. SHOMO CAMP - CONTINUOUS

DARK falls like a lid.

For a few seconds there is only the roar of the troopers overhead, two moving flames on a black field. And under it, from the pen, a sound Indy hears clearly in the ringing quiet:

An iron strap, long loosened, tearing off its timber.

He runs. He makes it eleven steps.

The nearer flame wheels in the sky like a lighthouse beam, sweeps down the shed, and finds him. Indy does the only thing available to a man in a spotlight. He stands perfectly still and hopes to be mistaken for a post.

FALK (O.S.)
Dr. Jones.

The flame comes down thirty feet away, boots first, in a spray of gravel and steam, like a man stepping off a streetcar. LEUTNANT FALK is young, with a pleasant bony face under a leather helmet, a pistol in one hand and a pair of Zeiss field glasses bouncing on his chest.

FALK
Forgive me. I have been asked to be firm. Leutnant Falk.

He bows his head a quarter of an inch.

Then he lifts two fingers to the peak of his helmet. Polite. Almost friendly. Indy has seen that salute before, through the glass nose of a Junkers over the Bay of Biscay.

INDY
Biscay. You were in the Ju 88.

FALK
I was. I am told you pulled very hard on my man's strap. He asked me to send his regards.

INDY
Tell him he's welcome.

FALK (CONT'D)
It is not personal.

INDY
You're the one who whistles.

FALK
Is it a fault?

He says it with real interest, and shoots at him.

Indy dives behind a stack of gray steel drums stenciled with a skull, giving off a sharp clean smell like the stuff you pour on a wound. The bullet whangs off the nearest. Falk's face changes.

FALK (CONT'D)
Please do not hide behind those. They are extremely expensive.

INDY
Then don't shoot them.

FALK
No. I must not.

He considers the problem with his head on one side, like a man looking for a better parking space. The valves hiss and he rises, slowly. Ten feet. Twelve. For an angle over the drums.

It is exactly what Indy has been waiting for.

He comes out at a dead run, jumps, and catches both boots.

The pack SCREAMS. For a moment it can't decide whether to lift the extra hundred and seventy pounds or throw them off. Falk says something in German that is probably a prayer.

Then the flames steady into a long roar, and the ground falls away.

EXT. SHOMO CAMP - IN THE AIR - CONTINUOUS

Twenty feet. Forty. Indy hangs from a stranger's ankles with the satchel swinging against his ribs and the camp turning below him like a map he drew himself. The black shed. The wrecked tents. The mules still stampeding in circles. Torches bobbing like fireflies. At the corner of the pen, a small patient hump that does not look up.

FALK
Herr Doktor, please let go. It will be easier for both of us.

INDY
You first.

FALK
I am unable.

The pistol comes down past his hip, hunting for an angle. Indy goes hand over hand up the harness until his face is an inch from the pack. Two cylinders. A cross-valve where the tubing meets. And a gauge needle already sinking. Falk came down for fuel, not a fight, and has perhaps half a charge left. With a hundred and seventy pounds of archaeologist hanging off him, a lot less.

He starts to count.

Falk gets the pistol round and jams it against Indy's ribs. Indy catches the wrist with his left hand, finds the cross-valve by feel, a stiff brass wheel the size of a biscuit, and turns it as hard as he can.

The left cylinder shuts off. The right goes on burning. The whole rig, which had been rising like an elevator, lurches into a long lopsided SPIN.

FALK (CONT'D)
Please! Please do not do that!

INDY
I read it in a bulletin!

The pistol goes off into the sky.

They corkscrew over the camp in a great shrieking spiral, trailing flame, past the tent tops, past the shed's chimney, so low a startled Bavarian looks up from the mud and falls over backward.

At twenty-six the pack COUGHS. Falk drops six feet. Catches himself. Drops six more.

INDY (CONT'D)
Thirty-one. Thirty-two.

They come down through the ruins of the mess tent like a bomb through a circus. Canvas gives. A table folds. A tureen of cold soup takes the whole impact with a sound like the end of the world. The pack gives one last sorrowful cough and goes out.

The two of them lie in a heap of ropes, playing cards and onions, steam rising off the leather.

Indy rolls off, gasping, trying to remember which arm he uses for things. Falk lies with his helmet askew and his face white as a plate, still holding the pistol. Slowly, with the exquisite manners of a man who hasn't noticed he's concussed, he begins to raise it.

FALK
I am so sorry, Herr Doktor.

A shadow falls across him: stout, aproned, a pipe clamped in its teeth, holding a cast-iron skillet. The MESS COOK looks down at the young lieutenant with the infinite weariness of a man who has put up with the army for three years.

He brings the skillet down on the helmet with a noise like a church bell.

Falk sighs and goes to sleep.

The cook looks at the skillet. He looks at Indy. He takes the pipe from his mouth, says one word in German that Indy doesn't know and understands perfectly, and puts the pipe back.

COOK
Quitt.

INDY
(hoarse)
Quits. Thank you for the bread.

The cook shrugs, as if bread were nothing, and goes off to see what has become of his soup.

Overhead the second flame is swinging round, searching. Indy checks the satchel, still buckled, still heavy. He pulls himself out of the wreckage and runs for the ledge with the taste of onions in his mouth and, for the first time since Biscay, a feeling uncomfortably close to joy.

EXT. THE PEN - CREVASSE EDGE - NIGHT

The only way out nobody guards is along the pen's far side, where the ground falls into a crevasse. Tsering said she'd meet him there. She isn't there yet.

The pen is thirty feet to his left, with a gap in its lower corner where the strap used to be.

The creature comes out through the gap at a walk.

It is larger than it was in the pen. It comes over the broken shoring on all fours and straightens, and in the orange light from the sky it is not a monster and not a man.

It carries something in its right hand. Indy doesn't see what until it stops six feet away and looks down at him from a height that makes him feel like a student.

A tin cup. The rice pressed down inside with a thumb.

Neither of them moves.

Indy has a revolver with five rounds and has never been less sure he wants it. After a moment he does the only thing he can think of. He lifts his left hand, slowly, palm out, and the red cord Tsering tied on his wrist swings forward in the light.

The creature looks at the cord. Looks at him.

It makes a sound deep in its chest, very low, with no words in it but with a shape: the shape of a thing said once to someone who might, in time, understand.

Then a trooper sweeps overhead, low, his pack howling, and the flame lights the ledge white. The creature flinches. It goes past Indy in a single bound, the shoulder catching him and spinning him round.

And the ledge, which has been holding for years on nothing but frost, gives way under his boots.

He catches the lip with both hands. His body swings out over the dark. The satchel strap slides off his shoulder and down his arm. He feels it go. Feels the weight leave him. Hears it hit something below and make no sound.

Tsering's hands close on his collar from above.

TSERING
I have you. Do not let go of me.

He doesn't.

When she has hauled him onto the snow and he lies on his back, fuel still wet on his hands and the generator silent and the camp screaming in the dark, he looks up at the sky and understands, with the clarity that comes only at the worst possible moment, that the report is gone.

And that there is exactly one way left to get it back.

EXT. THE CREVASSE - NIGHT

Narrower than the one Indy imagined, which is the only mercy the mountain offers tonight.

He goes over the edge on a rope Tsering has anchored round a boulder with hands that stop shaking the moment there is work to do. The ice closes around him in grades of dark: blue-gray near the surface, black within thirty feet, with the cold of glacier water that kills a strong swimmer faster than a weak one, because the strong ones keep trying long after the sense has gone out of trying.

He finds the satchel by touch, wedged in a crack six feet to his left, out of reach of any arm. He unhooks the whip. The first throw misses. The second finds the strap. The third brings the satchel swinging into his hand like a trout, the canvas already stiff.

EXT. CREVASSE EDGE - CONTINUOUS

Tsering hauls him up hand over hand. He can't feel his fingers well enough to know he still holds it until he sees the satchel clutched against his chest.

TSERING
Breathe. Breathe, American, before you forget how.

She pulls him flat onto the snow.

Above them, the fighting has moved up the slope toward the snowfield, where Voss's men are chasing a shape that moves faster across broken ground than any of them can follow.

But one man hasn't gone. KESSLER stands at the crevasse's edge, pistol hanging loose in one hand, his face lit from below by a dropped torch guttering in the snow.

INDY
(getting to his knees)
You didn't fire.

KESSLER
It went past me. Within the length of this arm. It had a cup in its hand, did you see? I had the pistol up. I have shot a great many things, Dr. Jones, and I did not decide to lower it.

He turns the pistol over as if it might carry an inscription.

KESSLER (CONT'D)
It looked at me and knew precisely what I was. A man is not often given an accurate review.

Tsering is on her feet with her father's Lee-Enfield steady on Kessler's chest. Indy hadn't expected the steadiness. He should have.

TSERING
Norbu.

Kessler does not flinch at the name.

KESSLER
He pronounced the German place names better than my own men. I corrected his English once and he corrected my Tibetan, and he was right.

He looks at the torch.

KESSLER (CONT'D)
I gave the order. I told Lang and Brenner to stop him before the lower valley. I did not say how. They understood me perfectly, and I knew they would.

His voice stays level, which makes it worse.

KESSLER (CONT'D)
I have spent four years improving the verb.

Her finger moves on the trigger, a fraction. Indy understands that the next half second belongs entirely to her, and that anything he does will either save Kessler's life or cost Tsering something she will carry the rest of hers.

INDY
Tsering.

TSERING
Do not tell me what this costs me.

INDY
I'm telling you what happens next. If you kill him here, nobody in Berlin or Lhasa or London ever hears the name Norbu. If he writes it down, they do.

The torch gutters lower. She holds the gun steady, longer than the cold or the hour should have allowed. Then she lowers it. It isn't graceful. Her arm has simply run out of whatever was holding it up.

TSERING
You write down every word you said to me. And you sign it. And I take it out of this country myself.

She doesn't lower her eyes.

TSERING (CONT'D)
If I ever hear your name in any paper, I will finish tonight.

Kessler looks at her. Then he nods once, sits down heavily in the snow, and begins, with hands that Indy notes are shaking for the first time, to write.

A flashbulb goes off like a small sun.

JO (O.S.)
That's a lovely confession. Take your time. I'm still changing film.

Kessler flinches. Tsering spins with the rifle up.

A woman steps out of the blue afterglow with a SPEED GRAPHIC slung across her chest like a bazooka and a Colt .45 held casually in her other hand. She looks at the rifle pointed at her.

JO
Honey, if you're going to point that at somebody, point it at him.

JOSEPHINE "JO" CALDER is around thirty, in a flight jacket two sizes too big and a fur-lined cap with copper hair escaping from under it, freckles across a nose that was broken once and improved by it, and a mouth that looks as if it has just thought of something it shouldn't say.

Indy knows the mouth. He last saw it in a Cairo bar on a Tuesday neither of them discusses.

INDY
Jo.

JO
Indiana.

She looks at Kessler with the unhurried interest of a woman pricing a horse.

JO (CONT'D)
You look terrible. Where's the hat?

INDY
A yak ate it.

JO
Of course it did. I've been following you since Rateng, and I've got to tell you, the trail was a joke. You left a sock.

Tsering doesn't look surprised. She looks, if anything, vindicated.

JO (CONT'D)
Donovan wanted pictures. Shaw wanted a witness and didn't tell you, because Shaw never tells anybody anything. I wanted to watch you make an ass of yourself on a mountain.

She holsters the Colt and holds out a hand to Tsering, who looks at it.

JO (CONT'D)
Josephine Calder, LIFE. I'd say it's a pleasure, but your gray mule bit me.

TSERING
He is a very honest mule. And I knew. Since the first pass. I wanted to see whether you could follow my animals as far as the fence.

INDY
You knew?

TSERING
You were busy being slow.

JO
Is that a compliment?

TSERING
It is arithmetic.

Jo grins. Then she looks down at the pen moving in Kessler's hand.

JO
Is that what I think it is?

TSERING
It is my brother's name. And what was done to him.

The wisecracking goes out of Jo's face. What's left is harder and more useful.

JO
Then I'll be your witness, ma'am. Every page, a negative of each, in three different places by sunrise. The negatives are yours. Nobody buries anything on my watch.

She takes the pistol out of Kessler's limp hand, as one lifts a salt shaker off a neighbor's plate.

JO (CONT'D)
I'll hold this.

Then the shouting changes above them. All four look up.

EXT. THE SNOWFIELD - NIGHT

Two hundred yards up the slope, a pale bowl in the dark, lit by the last trooper hovering over it on a fresh charge. By his long orange flicker Indy sees everything at once.

Voss's men, fanned across the slope, rifles up. A machine-gun team wrestling an MG 34 onto its bipod. Four more dragging a net the size of a tennis court.

And in the middle, quite alone, standing in the open like a man who has come out to see what all the noise was about: the CREATURE. Without the fence to measure against, he keeps getting bigger. He still holds the tin cup.

VOSS (O.S.)
(megaphone, shrill)
Lebendig! The specimen is to be recovered alive! Unharmed!

KESSLER
(murmuring)
Voss. He wants a photograph.

Jo's hands have gone to the Speed Graphic before her brain catches up.

JO
Oh, that's a cover. That's every cover for ten years.

She brings it up. Then the creature turns his head and looks at them, down two hundred yards of night. She stops. She lowers the camera.

JO (CONT'D)
(to nobody)
No. Not that one.

The machine gun opens up: a long ripping burst fired high to herd him. The creature looks at it the way a cat looks at a vacuum cleaner.

The net goes spinning out and comes down over him. The whole line of soldiers begin, absurdly, to cheer.

He closes one hand on the netting and pulls.

Four men who've been holding the ropes leave the ground in a neat row, like laundry, and sail off across the snow in four directions. The net comes with him. He shakes it out once, the way a man shakes a tablecloth, and flings it back over the machine-gun nest. The gun stops. So do the gunners, in a heap, under a hundred pounds of wet hemp.

JO
(faintly)
Nobody told me he was going to be this good.

Every rifle on the slope goes off together. They're aimed low, for Voss's sake, and the creature moves like water round a stone: a stride left, and the bullets eat the snow where he was. One enormous arm sweeps sideways and takes three men off their feet like a scythe through wheat. He comes up with the machine gun in both fists, tripod and all, and uses it. It rings off helmets like a church bell. A sergeant goes over backward. Another sits down quite politely, holding his jaw.

The creature finds the weapon unsatisfactory. He bends it double across his knee and drops it. The sound it makes hitting the snow is the saddest noise Indy has ever heard from a machine.

VOSS (O.S.)
Forward! Alive! The specimen is to be—

A pause.

VOSS (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Recovered!

JO
(delighted)
He dropped the "alive."

The survivors come in all at once, a dozen at least, bayonets out. The creature lets them. He stands in the middle of the snowfield and looks down at the white under his feet. Tilts his head. Listens.

TSERING
(her hand on Indy's arm)
Oh. He knows the snow.

He draws back one huge fist and drives it down into the shelf like a man striking an anvil.

The crack runs away from his hand in every direction, a bright thread across the bowl. The whole slope below him sits up and sighs. The first line of soldiers has time to look down. The second has time to shout.

Then half an acre of snow, with twelve men standing on it, folds and slides with a roar down the long white slope toward the broken fence, taking a net, a tripod, a good deal of Voss's dignity, and every rifle on the field.

INDY
Everyone in this valley knows the snow, except the Germans.

TSERING
That is why we are still alive.

EXT. CREVASSE EDGE - CONTINUOUS

The last trooper has been dropping back to the drums for fuel and climbing out again, circling, waiting for a clean pass. He comes down now. He doesn't go for the creature. He goes for the knot of figures at the edge of the crevasse: the satchel, the man with a pen.

Whatever Voss's orders were, the young man has a better one of his own. The harness howls. The flame lengthens to a white lance, and he comes down the slope at forty miles an hour with a pistol thrust ahead like a man spearing a fish.

Tsering begins to count under her breath, in Tibetan.

INDY
Thirty.

TSERING
Forty.

INDY
Jo, if you've got anything—

JO
Hold your horses.

She has the lens cap off, a fresh bulb snapped into the reflector, and her thumb on the shutter. She has, Indy notices, the steady stillness of a woman who has stood in front of worse than this and made it smile.

The trooper fills the sky. Indy can see his teeth.

JO (CONT'D)
(gently)
Look at me, sweetheart.

She fires.

The bulb goes off like the end of the world. It fills the crevasse with white. The trooper, who has spent the last hour in the dark with his eyes wide open, SCREAMS and flings both hands over his face, and the flame, so perfectly aimed, goes howling off in a great blind curve. He misses Kessler by a yard and the crevasse by another. Indy feels the heat pass over his scalp like an iron.

He is already coming round again: blind, steering by the howl of his own flame, straight back at the crevasse. Lower this time.

Indy has the whip off his belt. He drops to one knee at the boulder where Tsering's rope is anchored, threads the whip's handle through the loop of the knot, and hauls it tight with his teeth.

TSERING
What are you doing?

INDY
Giving him something to be on the end of.

He stands up in the snow, alone, directly in the trooper's path, with a coiled bullwhip and the perfect stillness of a man hoping to be mistaken for a post.

The flame comes down the slope like a lit fuse. Indy can see the scorched face behind it.

CRACK.

The lash uncoils across the dark and wraps the trooper's ankle.

The line goes taut. The knot holds. The boulder groans. The trooper stops in mid-air as though he has run out of sky. Then he swings, a rocket-powered pendulum, round and round the boulder on fifteen feet of leather, screaming, his flame carving a white circle in the snow. Indy rides the other end of it on his heels, boots plowing two furrows, and does not let go of the knot.

KESSLER
(not looking up from his page)
That is a remarkably good whip.

INDY
(through his teeth)
It's an old whip.

TSERING
Seventy.

The pack SPITS. Sputters.

Out on the slope, a great shadow comes up off the snow with a boulder the size of a bread oven in both hands. The creature, who has apparently been waiting only for somebody to hold him still, leans back.

And throws.

It takes the trooper out of the sky in a single hit. The flame goes out. The whip goes slack in Indy's hands. The man drops with a thin rising shriek into the runout and lands with a soft thump, his ankle still in the lash, and does not move, and does not die: the pack has folded around him like a cradle. Somewhere in the dark Voss's megaphone gives a small squawk and says nothing further.

It is very quiet.

The creature stands alone on the scoured slope, steam rising off his shoulders. A few of the men he's scattered crawl toward the camp. He doesn't follow them. He lowers his arms.

Then, slowly, he looks down the long slope toward the crevasse, and Indy feels the weight of that gaze come across two hundred yards of darkness and stop, like a hand laid flat, on the four of them at the edge.

Kessler has stopped writing. Nobody breathes.

The creature raises the tin cup, once, until it catches a little of the dying light. It might be a salute. It might be a man checking that his dishes are clean.

Then he turns and goes up the snowfield and over the ridge, into the high white country where no airplane will ever follow. The dark closes behind him.

TSERING
(softly, to the
place where he was)
Migoi.

KESSLER
Accurate.

He goes on writing.

Jo stands with the Speed Graphic hanging in her hands and a very peculiar look on her face. She has a great many things to say, Indy can tell, and she is going to say none of them. She takes a flask from her jacket, drinks, and holds it out to him.

JO
I had the shot. I had the whole shot.

INDY
I know.

JO
Best picture I ever didn't take.

She screws the cap back on.

JO (CONT'D)
Don't tell Luce.

EXT. CREVASSE EDGE - LATER

Kessler writes until the torch burns down to a stub. When he has signed the last page he holds it out to Tsering without looking at her. She takes it without looking at him. That is the whole of the exchange.

Indy opens the satchel on his knee by the last of the light and takes out the leather folder. For a minute he only holds it.

It is the best thing he has ever put his hands on, and he knows it. Tables. Drawings. A careful account, in a scholar's hand, of what the thing in the pen is, how it stands, how it eats, what it counts. No museum in the world wouldn't hang his name over the door for it. Somewhere at the back of his head, in the lecture hall where he lives, a voice a good deal like his own has already begun drafting the footnotes.

KESSLER
You will want to publish. I did. It is a very good report.

INDY
It's the best I've ever read.

That is the trouble with it.

He takes out the photographs of the Tibetan men first: the faces on the stool with calipers at their temples. Squares them into a stack. Holds them out to Tsering.

INDY (CONT'D)
Those go back to their families. Whoever can be found.

She takes them in both hands and does not thank him. He understands this is a courtesy.

Then he tears from his notebook the pages where he copied Kessler's lines and lays them on top of the folder.

TSERING
You kept it dry.

INDY
I'm about to un-keep it.

JO
(very softly, for her)
Indy. That's the story of the decade.

INDY
It's a skull in a case the minute anyone but him reads it. Somebody in Berlin or Washington or London reads this and starts planning a better-equipped expedition. I'd like the mountain to stay a rumor a while longer.

He picks Kessler's dropped torch out of the snow and puts it to the corner of the folder. The paper tries to curl away, the way paper does. Then gives up. It burns slowly, with a great deal of light. The four of them watch four years of one man's work go up in a column of sparks that the wind carries east.

KESSLER
(hoarse, tired)
It is Old Babylonian.

INDY
What?

KESSLER
The sign. In your footnote.

Indy looks at the fire.

INDY
I know. I've known since the day it ran. Write that down too, if you like.

Kessler lets out a single dry breath that might, in a happier man, have been a laugh.

Tsering watches until the last page goes.

TSERING
Good. It weighed a great deal.

EXT. EDGE OF THE CAMP - DAWN

Gray light. Smoke. Wrecked tents. Pemba limps toward them out of the confusion: bruised, battered, but upright, having slipped away in the chaos of the specimen's escape.

Tsering reaches him first. She says nothing. She puts a hand against his bruised face and holds it there a moment. He nods, embarrassed.

Of the creature there is no trace in the camp. But above it, on the snowfield, Indy finds the tracks: too large, too widely spaced for any animal he can name, heading up and east into country no transport plane will ever reach.

At the top, where the tracks cross the ridge, he finds the TIN CUP.

It lies on its side in the middle of the tracks, empty and clean, as if rinsed. Someone has scratched a mark into the rim with a stone.

A single short stroke. The first line of a new row.

He doesn't pick it up. Tsering comes up beside him, arms folded, and looks at it for a long time.

TSERING
(quietly)
One.

EXT. SNOWFIELD ABOVE SHOMO - NOON

Voss comes up the snowfield a little before noon, on foot, with what's left of his men: eleven, bandaged and filthy and silent, no megaphone. Stoll is among them, a rag tied round his head, his rifle carried like a mop. So is the Young Guard with the scab on his chin, who looks at Indy and then very carefully at the sky.

Voss himself has lost a lens from his spectacles. In his left hand he carries what remains of a gramophone record, a curved black shard, the way a man carries the remains of a hat.

They stop at thirty yards. Rifles come up in a ragged line, without conviction.

Indy, Tsering, Jo, Pemba and Kessler stand at the ridge. Kessler has the signed pages folded inside his coat.

VOSS
(to nobody in particular)
The documents are to be returned. And the Obersturmbannführer.

INDY
The folder's ash. The confession isn't yours. Miss Calder has every page on film, Herr Doktor, in three places, and you won't find all three.

He takes a step forward.

INDY (CONT'D)
You wanted a report so clean no journalist could prove it a fraud. You're holding the dirtiest paper in Asia: a Reich officer, signed and dated, confessing murder on Tibetan soil. It goes to LIFE magazine, and it is going to be very hard to turn into a curiosity.

Voss looks at Kessler.

KESSLER
It is true. I signed it.

VOSS
Feldwebel.

He lifts his hand.

Stoll does not raise his rifle. He looks at the Herr Doktor with his closed-door face.

STOLL
(English like a dropped crate)
The Herr Doktor said gently. To shoot is loud.

TSERING
(quietly)
Do not speak. It is noon.

The WIND STOPS.

It doesn't die. It ceases, all at once, and the silence is so total Indy can hear a rifle sling creak thirty yards away. A man coughs, and is ashamed.

And from somewhere far above them comes a sound: low, a long note with no words in it and the shape of a word, like a horn blown a mile off under water.

Then it is answered from the left, from farther up. Then from the right. Not one voice but many, passing the call from ridge to ridge the way fires are passed.

Eleven rifles go down by degrees, without anyone telling them to.

EXT. THE HIGH RIM - CONTINUOUS

On the rim across the saddle, in the flat white noon, with their hair hanging straight because there is no wind to lift it, stand the PEOPLE OF THE MOUNTAIN.

Indy tries to count them and his eyes give up at thirty. They are tall, and still, and spaced along the skyline like a congregation. They look down at the men on the ridge without hostility and without any particular interest, as people look at weather.

Jo has the Speed Graphic halfway to her face. She looks at Tsering. Tsering does not say a word.

Jo lowers the camera.

That is the second best picture she never took.

VOSS
(very quietly)
A kind of goat.

Nobody answers him.

Then the wind comes back out of the east with a long dry rush, and the rim is empty, as though it had never been anything but snow and sky.

Voss stands a long moment. He looks at the shard in his hand. He opens his fingers and lets it fall.

VOSS (CONT'D)
The aircraft will leave at two. The Obersturmbannführer will accompany it, to account for the loss of the specimen. There is nothing else to account for.

He turns to Indy. For a moment he is only a tired man in a cracked pair of spectacles.

VOSS (CONT'D)
I have two daughters. I will tell them it was a very large kind of goat.

INDY
Tell them it was shy.

Voss nods, as at a figure he had expected, and leads his men down the snowfield.

Kessler gets up, brushes the snow from his knees, and follows. At the edge of the ridge he turns and says to Tsering:

KESSLER
Norbu Wangmo.

He says it correctly.

She says nothing. He goes.

EXT. THE SADDLE ABOVE SHOMO - TWO O'CLOCK

They watch the Junkers lift out of the east valley, three engines laboring in the thin air, a gray shape going small against the sky. It carries a crate marked FRAGILE with nothing in it but broken shellac, and one Obersturmbannführer who asked for a seat by the window.

EXT. THE TRAIL TO RATENG - NIGHT

A small fire. The walk back takes five days instead of four, nobody in a hurry to outrun anything.

Tsering has gone to check the animals. Pemba comes to Indy on his heels, looks at his own hands.

PEMBA
You promised the first thing.

INDY
I did.

PEMBA
Please write it now. I would like to see it written.

Indy takes out the small notebook he's carried since Mexico, wet at one corner, and a pencil with a Reich eagle stamped on it. He's stopped feeling bad about that.

INDY
Tell me how it's spelled.

PEMBA
Lhakpa.

He says it slowly.

PEMBA (CONT'D)
There is a breath after the first sound, like a man blowing on cold hands. The Germans say it flat, "Lakpa," and it is wrong. Lhakpa Dorje. He was thirty-four. He had two children, a boy and a girl. The girl is Dechen.

Indy writes it three times on three lines until Pemba nods. Then adds the date, the place, and the number on the truck's door, and signs it.

Pemba puts the notebook against his forehead, briefly, the way a man does with a prayer book. And gives it back without a word.

EXT. THE TRAIL - ANOTHER NIGHT

Jo walks out with them, which she describes as a favor and Tsering describes, to nobody in particular, as one more animal that talks. She has shot every page of the confession twice by torchlight and sewn the negatives, which are Tsering's, into three places: the lining of her jacket, the heel of her left boot, and, over Tsering's loud objection, the mule's saddle blanket.

The gray mule bites her twice on principle. Then, for reasons of its own, stops.

Tsering hands her a bowl of tea without a word. Jo takes a swallow and goes very still.

JO
Good God. That's a war crime.

TSERING
It is butter.

JO
It's a candle in a bowl.

She looks into it. Then drinks the rest, carefully, to the bottom, and holds out the bowl for more.

Tsering looks at her a long moment and refills it. Across the fire, Indy understands that something has just been decided without anyone saying a word.

JO (CONT'D)
You could come to Washington. I'd put you in LIFE. Two pages, full color. "The Woman Who Walked Out of Shomo."

TSERING
I do not carry what it does not need.

JO
I'm needed.

TSERING
You are loud.

JO
That's what makes me needed.

Her eyes go to the red cord on Indy's wrist and stay there.

JO (CONT'D)
Who tied the knots on that?

INDY
It's wool. It's warm.

JO
Sure it is.

She looks across the fire at Tsering, who studies the flames with the closed, careful face of a woman who has heard nothing. Jo grins like a cat in a creamery.

JO (CONT'D)
Sure it is.

EXT. THE HIGH PASS - DAY

The cairn, hung with white prayer flags that rattle like paper tearing. Tsering stops, as she stopped coming up. Indy waits.

She circles the cairn, touching a stone. On the way in she walked it clockwise. This time she goes the other way, slowly, and he understands without being told that there is a version of the ritual for the living and another for the dead, and that she has just moved from one to the other.

She takes a pinch of tsampa from her pouch and sets it on the cairn, the way you leave a plate for a man who is late.

TSERING
Go on. I will catch you.

He goes on. She does, after a mile. Her eyes are dry and her face is the same as it was. He doesn't say a word about any of it.

It is, he thinks, the one promise he's ever managed to keep without being asked.

EXT. THE TRAIL - LAST NIGHT BEFORE RATENG

A fire. The lights of the trading post visible far below. They read Kessler's confession properly by firelight. It is everything Indy hoped: the snares, the order, the four years of silence, signed in a hand that would satisfy any magistrate in any country he can think to send it to.

Under the signature, Kessler has added a line in a smaller, steadier hand. Indy reads it out. Tsering makes him read it twice.

KESSLER (V.O.)
I request that the name of the guide be given in all copies as Norbu Wangmo, and not "the guide," nor "N." as it appears in my notes. This was an omission of mine and I would correct it.

TSERING
It is a very small thing to ask for. It is also the first time he has used his name.

Folded inside is a photograph, curled at the edges: a broad-faced man on a stool, calipers at his temples. In pencil beneath: N. Wangmo, guide. Spricht Englisch. Kessler has added a second line in ink, small and slanting. Indy translates it aloud because Tsering asks.

KESSLER (V.O.)
Taken three days before. He asked me not to use it. I have kept it anyway.

She holds the photograph by the edges, as if it might smudge.

TSERING
He chipped his tooth. On a mule, when he was ten. I told our father it was the mule's fault.

She turns it over, looks at the blank back, turns it face up again.

TSERING (CONT'D)
He was thirty-one in this picture. He does not look afraid.

INDY
No.

TSERING
He looks like he is trying not to laugh at the man with the calipers.

She puts it inside her coat, against her chest, and says nothing else until morning.

INT. THE RESIDENCY - GANGTOK - DAY

Whitcombe receives them with considerably less surprise than Indy expected from a man who sent him on foot toward a valley full of rocket troopers.

WHITCOMBE
Shaw's cable says there's a plane for you at Dinjan on Thursday. Back into the war proper, I'm afraid. He didn't say which theater.

INDY
He never does.

WHITCOMBE
The American mission reached Gangtok on Tuesday, by the way. They've been asking where their academic adviser has got to.

INDY
Tell them he's late with his grades.

WHITCOMBE
I said something very like that. They didn't laugh either.

Boots on gravel. American voices in the hall, one of them asking loudly whether the professor has been located. Whitcombe, without a flicker, points at the window curtain. Indy is behind it, in a yak-hair coat that could not look less like a professor, when two men in pressed suits walk in and ask whether Dr. Jones has turned up.

WHITCOMBE (CONT'D)
Not for some days. He did mention he was late with his grades.

AMERICAN DIPLOMAT
Of course he is.

They leave. Indy comes out from behind the curtain in a cloud of dust. In the doorway, a flashbulb pops.

JO
For the file.

Whitcombe glances at Tsering, who stands at the window with her pack still on her shoulder, having refused every offer of a chair, and at the other young woman leaning in the doorway with two cameras round her neck and a look of patient suffering.

WHITCOMBE
And the young ladies?

INDY
Miss Wangmo goes her own way from here. She has a report to deliver that doesn't belong to either of our governments.

WHITCOMBE
Good luck to her, then.

He raises his glass half an inch, which is as close to a toast as the man is built to manage.

JO
And Miss Calder is going to Washington with a hundred and forty exposures of scenery and a very low opinion of the Himalaya. Also, Mr. Whitcombe, you owe me a drink.

Whitcombe looks at the decanter. Then, with the air of a man amending a treaty, pours a second glass.

Indy tears out the three lines Pemba approved and lays the page on the desk.

INDY
That goes to Shaw with my report. Marked for the file, not for the clerks.

Whitcombe reads it.

INSERT - THE PAGE

In Indy's handwriting: Lhakpa Dorje, 34. Killed 14 September, German supply truck, depot road below Shomo. Wife and two children survive. No compensation paid. Below it, three words: Spell it right.

WHITCOMBE
I'll see it's done properly.

INDY
I didn't tell you how.

WHITCOMBE
No. But you've underlined it twice, Dr. Jones, and I have been in this country a long time. I know what it means when a man underlines a name twice.

EXT. THE RESIDENCY - GATE - DAY

Tsering leaves before the jeep comes. No ceremony. A nod at the door and the economy of movement he's come to know as hers.

At the gate she stops and turns. From her pack she takes a battered black felt hat, its brim bent by someone else's years, and sets it on Indy's head without asking. She tilts the brim down with two fingers.

TSERING
Norbu had a very large head.

INDY
What do I owe you?

TSERING
Nothing. It was not mine to sell.

Indy watches her go down the gravel drive toward the road east, toward wherever four years of carrying a letter ends and whatever comes after begins. He doesn't call after her. She hasn't asked him to.

Jo goes after her with a small flat tin. At the gate the two of them stand a moment, the tall one and the short one. Jo puts the tin in Tsering's palm and closes her fingers over it.

Then Tsering takes a length of red wool from her pack and ties it round Jo's wrist without asking, with two small hard knots, and pulls each one until it bites.

Jo comes back up the drive with the cord on her wrist and an expression she plainly intends never to explain.

At the jeep, Whitcombe reaches into his coat and gives Indy a small dented tin as if handing over a dispatch.

WHITCOMBE
Cheese. It's dreadful. Take it anyway.

INDY
I broke a tooth on the last cheese.

WHITCOMBE
This isn't that cheese. It's from my mother. She sends one every Christmas, and I've never once been able to eat it. I thought you might have better luck.

INT. C-47 - OVER THE HUMP - DAY

Indy eats half the cheese. Whitcombe was right: it's dreadful. Jo, in the next seat, takes the rest out of his hand without asking and finishes it anyway.

Somewhere below, the last of the high peaks fall away into cloud. Indy sits with the torn notebook in his jacket, thinner by eleven pages. For the first time in his working life he has nothing to publish. Ahead of him the war goes on exactly as it did before he went up.

JO
(not opening her eyes)
What was that peak called? The one behind the valley.

INDY
Lhari.

JO
What does it mean?

Indy looks out at the cloud where it was.

INDY
It means the people who named it knew who lived there.

JO
Wake me when it's interesting.

She pulls her cap over her face and puts her boots up on a crate of mail.

Indy turns his wrist in the light. The red cord is still there. He hasn't been able to cut it off, and he finds he has stopped trying.

Norbu's hat rides on his knee. He puts it on. It fits exactly, which is its own small mystery.

Through the window, far behind them, above the clouds, one white peak catches the sun.

FADE OUT.

THE END